

DOMINATED BY THEIR LANDLORD

REZA'S COMING



KT MORRISON

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ABOUT THE AUTHOR

KT Morrison writes stories about women who fall in love with sexy men who aren't their husband, and loving relationships that go too far—couples who open a mysterious door, then struggle to get it closed as trouble pushes through the threshold.

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Models on cover are meant for illustrative purposes only.

All characters are over the age of eighteen.

REZA'S COMING

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THESE FUCKING WINGS were driving him nuts. He got them rigged, but getting them to flap properly, at least when they rose up high above the character's shoulders, caused so much clipping he wanted to punch his computer screen. He was animating angels for some young Korean-American startup company, paying him one-tenth of what he was worth, but he could work fast and get out the mods they wanted, and more work equals more money.

He'd rigged a lot of this company's models this month. Last month too. Angels, demons, knights on horses; making weapons for them, adding fire to some of their regular weapons. They paid, and that's what it was all about.

It would be close this month. Eight freelance gigs plus development on his own game had stressed him out, pushed him to the limit. Two all-nighters this month, and when he did sleep, it was often only for three or four hours at a time. Today was the 31st, and he was screaming for the finish line, running so fast his feet were on fire. It was close, so close.

He had to pay the interest on the principal of his debt first then make the payments, plus back rent, and, of course, current rent. Charlie covered groceries and the other incidentals. If these Koreans could manage to PayPal him his money tonight, they might just be okay this month.

“Come on, come on,” he said, whipping the mouse left and right then attacking the keys, slamming out code on a pop-up menu trying to fix this son of a bitch.

The key rattled in the door behind him, inserted into the lock and twisting then a tapping against the door that he knew would be her pewter cat’s face key chain. The door was opened and his beautiful wife came home.

“Fuck it,” he sighed, sliding his office chair back from his workstation and watching this dumb angel flap its wings, its lower feathers slicing in and out of its torso and head, the damned son of a bitch thing.

He spun the chair around with the heels of his socks and regarded his Charlie as she came into the kitchen closing the door behind her and putting her purse on the table, plastic bags up on the kitchen counter. He could hear the rattle of dry pasta in boxes inside those bags. He watched her pretty head bob left and right in the kitchen pass-through, him in the lower living room/bedroom, his girl moving around solemnly in their kitchen, opening cupboards and putting things away. She hadn’t said hello.

“Hi Charlie,” he said.

“Hey,” she said quietly without looking through the passage. He got out of the chair and joined her, walking up the two steps to be in the kitchen.

He asked, “What’s wrong?”

“Nothing,” she said, still not looking at him, holding three boxes of pasta and sliding them onto a shelf just above her head.

“Did something happen?”

“No, Jonny, nothing happened.”

“Are you worried?”

She chewed at her lower lip, head nodded forward with her hands resting on their countertop. She looked like she bore an enormous weight.

He asked her, “Is it tomorrow?”

She nodded.

“I think we’re going to be okay,” he told her.

“Are we?”

He went to her, put his hands on her shoulders and pressed his chest to her back. “Charlie I’m doing everything I can.”

“I know you are, Jonny. I know. It’s not that you’re not trying, it’s just —”

“Just that it’s not enough?”

“I’m sorry, Jonny.”

“Why are *you* sorry?”

She twisted herself so that her rump leaned on the counter and she put her hands on his chest but she couldn’t look in his eyes. “I don’t want to make this harder for you. I know you don’t like pressure.”

“It’s not that I don’t like pressure, Charlie, it’s just that I can’t possibly do more than what I’m doing.”

“I know, Jonny, I watch you, I see what you do.”

“We’ll get out of this, Charlie, I swear.”

She showed him a brighter face, the slightest hint of a smile pulling up the corner of her mouth. “Promise?” she asked him.

“I do, Charlie, I do. You don’t have to do anything this month.”

“Okay,” she said softly, her mouth twisting around, her brow furrowed in pensive demonstration. “You have enough?” she asked him, her voice rising in inflection, sounding hopeful but tinged with realism.

“I will. I just have to finish this angel I’m working on, send it to them, and they’ll pay me.”

“That’s good,” she said. Still her pouting little mouth twisted back and forth.

“Hey, look at me, Charlie,” he said, his hand coming up, his first knuckle stroking the bottom of her chin. “Look at me. What are you thinking?”

“I want you to make it, Jonny ...”

“Is there a but?”

“If we ... If I ...”

“If you what, Charlie? You mean sleep with him?”

“If I do that thing I do with him, then we can breathe.”

“Breathe?”

“You know what I mean, Jonny.”

Now she looked up at him, her trembling wet green eyes peering through her brows at her husband. The weight of her unsaid words heavy on her shoulders, being transferred onto his now. He knew what she was saying. If the Koreans sent the payment on time Charlie wouldn't have to do the dirty thing she did with their landlord to make their rent. But it would be another month of sleepless nights, round-the-clock coding and animating, living off of tap water, Kraft Dinner, and hot dogs for protein. If she did the thing that she did the previous months, something they'd all become accustomed to now, he could sleep at night a little. Still work, still put in the hours needed to make money, but maybe it would give a little breathing room. Maybe they could eat out a bit. Maybe they could go see a movie, who knows?

The things she did with their landlord, only one day of the month, did make their lives easier. At least financially. It was hard to take, hard to watch, hard to comprehend his arousal over the predicament. Hard to comprehend his wife's arousal, as unwanted as she claimed it was, over this other man who went inside her. There was a lot of things about this arrangement that challenged his psyche, that stabbed his heart.

JONNY KNEW WHAT SHE MEANT. If she were to be intimate with their landlord tomorrow that would be the fifth time they were together. And then add that one time she used her mouth on him at their kitchen table

when they thought that might be a way out of the mess they got themselves into.

Those first few times had been hard. So weird, so awkward, and so dirty. After she had used her mouth on him, she had been sick in the toilet. And after that first night, when Reza took her while Jonny watched, she had cried. Jonny rubbed her back, and she hugged her pillow to her face and sobbed and sobbed. Sobbed until she fell asleep, and then she woke and did it all over again. Got up the next morning and she could barely walk. Had to call in sick that day for work.

If she did that dirty thing with him tomorrow it would be the fifth time. What was one more time now really, anyway? She did it once, what was once more?

If he got close to making the money he needed this month, and then she also did that dirty thing, then maybe next month wouldn't be so scary. They could live a little, buy the things Charlie liked. Ice cream, some real fruit, some real vegetables, they could even get themselves some roast beef, maybe a tenderloin. Charlie would do them up in the oven and they could live off of leftovers for a good week. Jonny could have roast beef sandwiches for lunch and she could maybe bring some to work, too.

Charlie said, "It's just one day a month that's bad. But if we just scrape by it will be followed by thirty more days of scrimping, thirty more days of poverty. I could trade one day for those thirty. Just think about it, Jonny."

"Think about it?" A disgusted sneer pulled up his mouth. He didn't step away but eased back, and she let her hands come off his chest. He pictured her with Reza and her face showed she wanted it.

He said, "Are you telling me you want to ... want to do it?"

"Jonny, no, don't be crazy. Oh, Jonny, I don't mean that. You know what I mean, you're just wanting to hear the worst."

"It is the worst."

"It's not, Jonny. What I said is true."

He averted his eyes, chin darting away, his face surly but softening. What she said *was* true, and he knew it. It was awful, but it was pragmatic. This decision should be easier than the first time, but it wasn't.

Charlie said, "It's what we do now. This is the way it is. We're a team and I can do this. Maybe just one more month. What you did this last month ...? I saw how hard you worked, I know what you can do. I believe in you. Next month will be better. Next month maybe I won't have to. But right now we have enough to just get by. I was ready for tomorrow. It takes a lot of preparation, and I was ready."

"I'm sorry, Charlie ..."

"Say it again," she whispered with a great big smile peeling her cheeks back. Her arms went around him.

"Sorry, Charlie." It was a pet saying, and he'd stumbled across it accidentally. Something her grandmother had always said to her, a saying from an old TV commercial. He looked it up one night and watched it with her on YouTube. Tried calling her Charlie Tuna after that but she didn't like it.

"Don't be sorry, Jonny," she said. "I love you."

Jonny put his hands on her shoulders and he looked in her eyes. "Next month you won't do it. I swear it, Charlie."

THEIR APARTMENT WASN'T big and Charlie closed herself in the bathroom so she could change. Normally they would feel free enough with each other to take their work clothes off after a long day and put on their pajamas or sweatpants while they talked. But Charlie was constricted, stressed, and he feared that this arrangement was making her timider. She had gathered up some of her things that she liked to wear at nighttime and brought them into the bathroom with her. She'd been in there for a while.

He worried that she was being pushed too far emotionally. So he set a pot of water on the stove and got it turned to high and while he waited for it to boil he went down to the living room level and slipped across the parquet floor to listen at the bathroom door.

The greatest fear he'd had before spying was hearing soft crying sounds. That would break his heart. If he caught her crying he would have to end this. Whatever it took, he would do it. This arrangement they'd come to was difficult, but for now it was working. If he found his Charlie crying he would have to gather his things up and go to Kansas with her, his head hung low. Her parents would have to know what a failure he was. That would be tough to live with, far tougher than allowing the things he allowed now.

But there were no sounds of crying. He heard the shower, arrived just in time to hear her turning the tap off, hearing the drips from her body as she stepped out from the tub and onto the tile floor, knowing she was naked in there, picturing her bare perfect feet on their tufted pale blue bathmat. There were no sounds of crying; she didn't sound upset, he was even sure that she was humming. Not sure of the tune, but it sounded churchy. Like a hymn.

There was a spritz from an aerosol can, then a sound like the eruption of foam. He took two steps away, then the implication of that sound stopped him. He crept back. Ear pressed to the door, he listened again.

What foam was spritzed from an aerosol can? Answer: Shave foam. Was she shaving her legs? It seemed an odd thing for the nighttime. Yet he heard drawers now opening, the sound of a plastic disposable razor clattering on the counter, other jars and lotions being moved around. Eyes on the pass-through to the kitchen where he saw steam beginning to rise from where the stovetop would be, their water almost ready to boil for tonight's pasta dinner, he heard a scratching. The sound of a brand-new razor passing over stubbly skin.

Incredibly, the sound aroused him. A sudden swelling pushed through the front of his briefs, and he tugged at it to align himself comfortably. Imagined her naked in their bathroom, worried, yet excited. Could picture her beautiful skin with its apricot sprinkling. Her bending at the waist to watch as she shaved that mound between her legs. Why would the idea that she prepared herself for another man be so exciting? There was no denying that all of this from the very beginning had definitely done something to him. It pounded his heart, raced his pulse, hardened him between his legs. Yes, he hated every second of it. Every fingerprint that disgusting man put on his Charlie drove him to fury. Not furious enough, however, that he would put a halt to this and come to his senses, let his wife off the hook, leave her dignity out of the equation of his failure.

“You okay in there?” he said, face close to the hollow-core door.

The scratching sound of what must be a razor stopped. There was a moment of silence, then Charlie said, “Yeah. Why?”

“Just checking.”

Her quiet voice said, “I’m okay.”

“What kind of pasta do you want?”

There was a dreadfully long pause.

“Macaroni,” she said.

“Okay.”

He shifted his weight on the floorboards to make sounds as if he was leaving but instead he listened. After a while, the sounds returned.

Skritch, skritch, skritch.

He was sure she was shaving in there. Quietly, he slipped away from the door and returned to the kitchen.

THE WATER BOILED, and steam billowed in his face. The flap of an already opened box of macaroni was pulled away and the remaining contents spilled into the pot with a dry clatter. The bubbling ceased.

With his back to the stove, Jonny leaned on the handle to the oven door where Charlie's tea towels from home (a gift from her mother during her last visit) were draped. He watched the bathroom door, wanting to see her emerge. Wanting to see her expression. He worried for her.

The process that led to his demure wife assuming the dirty task of servicing their landlord in lieu of rent was a difficult one. Charlie had been so supportive during the legal proceedings, never once believing her husband was guilty. She had his back and accompanied him to the depositions. Dressed like his prim and proper wife with her hair pulled back and her dress shirt buttoned right up to the top button. Holding his hand and patting it until he was called. She couldn't believe the judgment against him. He couldn't tell her the truth. To make things better, he told her they would be fine, he had savings, he would get a job. It made matters worse. Just more lies.

Sure he had savings, but those assets were seized and held in trust for the investors. Behind closed doors—behind her back—a payment plan was arranged. Soon it became obvious they were in a deep financial crisis and

his lies would no longer stick. He came clean. Left out the part how he was actually guilty, but told the truth about how he was (they were) cleaned out. The money she earned would also have to go to the investors. They were husband and wife after all. His failure would become her burden.

And what about getting a job, Jonny?

Well, Charlie baby, see, I've been asking around ...

Yeah, maybe Charlie didn't know the truth of his guilt but word on the gaming street was clear—don't trust Jonny Keen. He was a pariah.

The art of game creation was in his blood, his heart pumped his passion and without it, he wouldn't be alive ...

Charlie, baby, I'll do freelance. I've done it before. I've lived off it before ...

That was true. Course, you were single then, weren't you, Jonny? Freelance was shit, but he would not work at a Subway, or sling hash at some diner. He had creativity bursting at the seams. Freelance would have to pay the bills. They had freelance, and they had Charlie's meager librarian income. Student loans and rent proved to make it almost impossible.

We could move, Charlie, I know how much you love the apartment, but ...

Then her waterworks came and if one thing in the world was his kryptonite, it was seeing that sweet angel shed tears. He swore to her he'd make it work ...

ONLY HE DIDN'T MAKE it work.

Butter melted and ground parmesan added, he stirred the mixture together with the pasta, added a little dash of milk. The door to the bathroom opened and Charlie came out, walked up the two steps to join him in the kitchen.

“Hey,” she said again, quiet. She wore a roomy sweatshirt, loose PJ bottoms that stopped mid-calf. “Dinner ready?”

“It is, baby,” he said.

He brought two plates to the kitchen table and set the grander portion in front of her. While he sat down she swapped them, giving him the plate with more pasta.

“Not hungry?”

She said, “No, I’m hungry. Thanks, Jonny, I just ... I just want you to have that plate.”

“Okay,” he said, tearing open the corner of a ketchup pack pilfered from the McDonald’s down the street. Charlie kept her gaze down, languidly moved a forkful of his steaming pasta into her pretty mouth.

No, he did not make it work, did he? And now look at your beautiful wife.

They’d put Reza off, and he was charming in a menacing way and Jonny assured him he would pay the amount in full the following month. Only he didn’t. Bills piled up, freelance payments came late or didn’t come at all (and he didn’t have time to chase them down), and slowly it became clear to Jonny that Reza knew Jonny was digging himself a large hole and he’d only handed Jonny the shovel with a smile.

Reza said it first. Not right out and plain and clear. Just an insinuation. “If only there were a way to pay me back. If only you had something of value.” He stood in their apartment, just the two of them, held a photo of Jonny and Charlie together, standing on the beach in Costa Rica. A sneer followed, narrowed eyes twinkling with evil delight.

And that was how it began.

Jonny resisted it at first. No fucking way. But they had to leave then, had to get out of the apartment.

He packed all their belongings and when Charlie came home from work one night, she found him in the hall ready to go. She collapsed on the floor.

No, Jonny, I can't go back to Kansas. Not like this. I love our apartment ... I'd do anything to keep it.

CHARLIE ASKED, "What do you want to watch tonight, Jonny?"

With the cable gone all they had left was an internet connection. That was his lifeline for work; a necessity. He downloaded the entire Twilight Zone library. Every episode, every season. "I got something special for you ..."

"What is it?" she said and her face seemed to brighten a tad.

"You'll see," he said, smiling sweetly at her. "After dinner." He was sure she would love the show.

Truth was, in retrospect, he was bluffing that night he'd packed their bags. Having them ready to go in the hall, standing with his coat on, apartment cleaned out ... that was performance. He wouldn't go back to Kansas with her. He wouldn't go to her parents and let them see what a failure he was. He'd made mistakes, sure, and he was paying for them, but the most important thing about Jonny—a guy who never had an easy shake—was his pride. Too proud to declare bankruptcy, too proud to move in with his in-laws. Why, oh why, wasn't he too proud to share his wife?

Told Charlie one morning, *Hey, I invited Reza for dinner tonight*. She said, *Okay*, her face growing a little troubled. He'd already told her how much they owed the landlord.

That day he'd blasted through work like he was on Adderall again. All day long moving like a hummingbird; a jolting live-wire hummingbird with an erection. Yeah, he was scared and nervous—and also surprisingly aroused. Profoundly aroused. That odd development was pushed away from the table; his arousal frightened him.

DINNER WITH REZA that evening had been intimidating. Charlie made a lasagna, the whole time anxiously working in the kitchen, her brow raised with worry.

Why did he want to have dinner with us, Jonny?

I invited him, Charlie.

Why, Jonny? We owe him so much money ...

Reza brought it up. After he picked through his lasagna with elaborate disinterest, he addressed them both and said that time had run its course; they would have to vacate the apartment. Charlie cried. Jonny consoled her. Charlie said they had rights. Reza agreed, however, the amount owing was substantial, and he had no fear, given the young couple's provable financial difficulties, that he would win any sort of contesting of their landlord/tenant contract. Jonny agreed with Reza and Charlie grew bewildered. "I don't want to go home, Jonny. I can't go home."

Jonny had held her hand then, quietly said, "Me neither, Charlie."

Charlie had whispered to him, "Oh Jonny, what are we going to do?"

Reza spoke up then, as if he had a complete understanding of the situation, looking over it like a chessboard. Knowing that Jonny hadn't prepared Charlie, knowing Charlie needed to be coerced, seeing Jonny put his pawn forward. Reza said, "Throughout history, Charlie, there have been many ways a young woman can find herself a way out of what seemed like a difficult situation. Do you know what I'm saying?"

Charlie had said no. But she was paying attention to him now. Charlie had her arms around Jonny at this point, on his lap where she had come to sit and whisper to him. She peeked over her shoulder now as Reza inched his chair forward so he could be closer.

He said, "I know you read, Charlie. I understand you're a librarian. You don't just handle the books, do you? I imagine you read quite a few."

"I have," she'd said.

“Even in the greatest classics what I’m suggesting has been written. As long as there has been literature, there has been the solution of which I’m talking. An age-old solution.”

“Yeah?” Charlie said, her voice a frightened and breathy gasp.

Reza inched his chair closer, his elbows on his knees, leaning forward with intent. His hands were close enough now that he could touch Charlie’s thigh. He said, “Charlie, you’re a beautiful girl. I’ve admired you for a long time.”

“You have?” she said, a certain tinge of fear in her voice.

“Sure,” Reza had said. “You hide your charms but a man like me can see them.”

“I did, too,” Jonny offered.

Reza ignored him, continued, “Now, I date a lot of beautiful women. It’s not that you have something to offer that I can’t get. But you have a certain sort of beauty that *could* be explored.”

“What do you mean?” she asked.

“Would you be opposed to going on a date with me?”

She had her arm around Jonny’s neck and she squeezed him, her head whipping around so she could look in his eyes. She gasped, sighing, “What’s he—”

“It’s okay,” Jonny had told her, “hear him out.”

CHARLIE'S LIPS, trembling, struggled to speak. Her eyes had darted over his and she stammered, "Jonny? You're not ...? He ... A date ...? You can't ..."

Jonny had put a hand over her trembling fingers on his chest. He tried to calm her. "What else are we going to do?" he said to her with great seriousness.

Now Reza said, "Hey, Charlie. Would you go out with a man like me?"

"I'm married," she whispered.

"If you weren't. If you weren't married, Charlie, would you like to go out with me?"

"I don't know."

"Jonny," Reza said, "tell her it's okay."

Jonny had rubbed the back of her hand, said, "Just tell him, Charlie."

"Tell him what?"

Reza said, "Do you think I'm handsome?"

"Jonny," Charlie gasped and looked away from Reza.

"Tell him, Charlie," Jonny soothed.

Reza repeated, "Many beautiful women find me attractive. Do you think I am attractive?"

“Yes,” Charlie said weakly and Jonny rubbed the back of her hand again. Between his legs, he was growing harder.

Reza moved even closer. He said, “Would you prefer to live on the street over spending a night with a man like me?”

Before she could answer, Jonny assured her, “It’s okay, Charlie.”

“It can’t be okay,” Charlie whispered but now her eyes were on Reza.

Reza said, “That’s all right, Charlie. I don’t need it. I have women begging to be with me. I hate to see you in such dire straits, I was merely offering you a glimmer of hope.”

“A date? With ... you?”

Reza said, “Sure,” and ran the knuckle of his first finger along the outside of her thigh. A spike of rage stabbed through Jonny’s heart. His eyes vibrated with violence. But under it all, the pounding of his heart was feeding the thing between his legs.

Charlie lowered her eyes and watched Reza’s hand as it grazed along her. “That’s all?”

“Honestly, Charlie ... No. I have lots of dates. But if you would date me, if you thought I was worthy of dating, surely you’d be capable of more.”

“Oh no,” she sighed. “More?”

“Well, Charlie. Both of us are very busy. I run two businesses, monitor this building, and I have a very ... active ... social life. And you ... you have a job, and you have a husband.”

“I *do* have a husband.”

“So, why would we go through all the dining when all I really want is dessert?”

“Dessert?” she gasped.

Reza said, “You like dessert, don’t you?”

“No,” she whispered.

But Reza was already moving. He leaned back in the kitchen chair, its metal frame squeaking under his bulk. His two hands came together at his

waist, and then the quiet of the kitchen was filled with a tiny sound with enormous implication. The teeth of his zipper coming apart as he ran it down.

Charlie and Jonny both watched, mesmerized by his boldness, his masculinity; they could both feel it. His hand searched inside the fly, brought out his manhood and dropped it. Jonny didn't know he would have such a monster. Didn't figure he was small but hadn't anticipated it would be so fearsome.

The idea that this threatening masculine weapon he saw dangling out of this strange man's fly was also seen by his quiet and shy wife had his pulse in the red zone. So overwhelming he could feel himself on the verge of passing out.

Reza's tool drooled from the open fly, long enough that the tip went below the seat of the chair. It was thick, and it was hairy. Uncircumcised, the drooping folds of his foreskin yawned open like a toothless mouth. Reza regarded them boldly. Impressive manhood presented to them, both his hands curled over the arms of the chair. His head cocked at a haughty angle, his brow lowered, his eyes on Charlie.

"What do you think?" he said.

THEN CHARLIE WAS IN MOTION, jumping up off of Jonny's lap and running to the sink. She had wrapped her hands over the lip, her nails scratching on the stainless steel. She bent over. Jonny ran to her, adjusting his arousal to conceal it, and hugged her.

"No, Jonny, no ..."

"It's terrible, it's so terrible," he said to her.

"I can't ..."

"You don't have to," he said. But he knew that she would. He wanted it, and it would save them. As terrible as it would be, it would allow them to

stay. It wouldn't be long until he could get them financially righted. *Or so he'd thought.* He asked her, "Charlie, what else can we do?"

"Nothing," she gasped.

Charlie looked over her shoulder as Reza said, "Please decide. I've got many other things to do tonight."

Jonny took her chin and aimed her face away. So offended, horrified—yet aroused—by the idea that she would be looking at that exposed penis presented to her. Aroused and enraged—and yet humbled. Truly and completely humbled. He didn't have what it took. It was the first glimmer of weakness that he ever had. This man had so much power over them.

Then, without saying a word, Charlie turned from Jonny's hold on her chin, put her eyes on Reza, folded her arms. Jonny hugged her, but she was rigid. She moved away from his embrace and returned to the chair in which Jonny had been sitting. Put herself knee-to-knee with Reza who sat across from her like a king on a throne.

Charlie whispered, "What do you want me to do?"

"I don't know if this is worth it. I want you to audition first. Show me what you can do."

"Audition?"

Jonny said, "Come on now."

"You owe me five months of rent. I will make it four just for the audition. If I like the performance, we can arrange a deal."

"Just tell me what you want," Charlie said.

Reza said, "I told you. I want dessert."

Charlie said, "You want me to eat dessert?"

Reza smiled, a sneer really, pulling up one cheek and narrowing his eyes. He said, "Show me how you love dessert."

Jonny came to stand behind her. He could see the muscles in her back trembling, could see her hands shake as she reached out and rested them on

Reza's knees. Then she eased herself off the kitchen chair and got to her knees between his legs.

"That's it," Reza encouraged.

His cock was completely flaccid, hanging heavy and lazy over the edge of the chair. When Charlie reached out and her bare and pretty fingers touched his dark and ugly club, Jonny literally dipped at the knees as if he would faint. It was awful. He had to support himself by leaning on the counter.

Without looking at him, his eyes still lowered to watch Charlie, Reza said, "You see okay from there, Jonny?"

He nodded. Charlie looked up over her shoulder at him. Her expression was sullen and sad, her skin waxen. He could see her lips trembling. He nodded again so that she could see. "What else are we going to do?" he whispered.

Before Jonny, Charlie had been a virgin. He was her first. She was inexperienced, and he had to show her everything. She'd gone down on him before, and it wasn't her favorite thing. But at least she knew the mechanics. Her pale hand lifted Reza's penis, and it buckled and fell out of her grip and swung. She picked it up again, supporting it with her second hand. Cradled it and lifted so she could put her mouth over the end.

"That's it," Reza said. "You're doing so good."

Jonny's mouth went instantly dry as he watched her take that soft tool past her lips. Gradually, Reza grew harder. His penis lengthening, becoming thicker, gaining enough rigidity that it would stop folding in half and falling out of his wife's hands. When he was almost fully hard, Charlie held it in both hands, watching it, her grip stroking up and down. It was an ugly cock. Veiny, thick and dusky-skinned. Charlie would have never seen an uncircumcised one before and she watched the foreskin peel and pucker. Reza had asked her, *Do you like it?* And when Charlie had said, *It's so big,*

Jonny had to sit down. His heart was pounding, his vision had gone white around the edges. His blood pressure must be through the roof.

Reza laughed, said, "You okay, Jonny?"

"No," he said weakly. He lay his palms on his wife's thin back. With her hands still gripping that enormous cock, she had looked over her shoulder at her husband. He tried to be strong but he couldn't. He tried to say her name but he couldn't even speak.

"Sorry," she whispered. "I'm sorry, Jonny."

"I am ... I'm sorry ..."

"It's okay," she whispered.

REZA HAD SAID, "Don't stop, Charlie. You're doing very well. I think we can come to some sort of agreement."

She returned her gaze to Reza, said, "Okay." Then she put her mouth over the fat shining glans, her fingers pulling his foreskin down the shaft, exposing it. Reza let his head fall back, and he groaned. Jonny watched that ginger head of hair bob up and down, her shoulders held up high, her elbows tucked in, her hands gently stroking while her mouth sucked on their landlord.

After a long while, enduring the most god-awful slurping and smacking noises, Reza's face began to take on frightening grimaces. Snarling and squinting. Low growls began to emanate from his chest. He grunted encouragement.

His hips began to thrust off the chair and into her mouth. "Come on, that's it, that's good ..." His teeth were clenched, bared, shining white in his black beard. His thick eyebrows lowered, his eyes narrow mean slits, twinkling light as he took in this horrible visage. A tenant's innocent wife submitting to him, her mouth stretched wide by his size.

Reza's head thrust back into the kitchen chair, he grabbed fistfuls of Charlie's beautiful apricot locks. His big meaty fists clenching and unclenching, then opening and polishing her skull like it was the globe of the world he was going to conquer. His breathing became loud and raspy, and Charlie began to make high squeaks of protest in her throat.

Reza gripped her fiercely. Big hands clenched in fists again, her beautiful hair woven in his grip and through his fingers. He clenched so tight his arms shook. Then he roared, plunged himself deep into her mouth and she snorted through her nose and made soft cries. He thrust and thrust again and Charlie's pale little hands scratched at his thighs like talons. Her little feet curled up in her slippers and her toes kicked on the linoleum. Charlie snorted and gasped for breath but her mouth was still full. Reza was coming in her mouth.

It was so horrible Jonny had covered his face. But he couldn't help watching. Witnessing the most awful thing he'd ever seen through the V of his spread fingers. Reza moaned and groaned and gasped for breath, his back thrust into their kitchen chair.

When he let her hair go, Charlie reeled back from him, wetly belching then coughing. She fell back on her rump and with her heels kicked herself across the floor away from Jonny and away from Reza. Her face was red, her eyes bleary. Her face was smeared wet, semen running out of her mouth. She was gasping for breath too, then erupted in violent coughing and gagging, rolling over onto her stomach and spitting on the floor.

Reza groaned again, long and low, sleepy eyes straight up at their kitchen ceiling while his hands came together and took that enormous wet thing and lay it inside his pants across his belly and zipped it closed, careful not to pinch it. He pulled his shirt down to cover the bulge, slowly sat himself up. He wiped at his mouth with the back of his hand. A vein flitted with his pulse behind the lion tattoo on his neck. He leaned forward on his

elbows again, regarded Charlie as she lay on the floor, still spitting. He said, “That wasn’t the best blowjob I ever had, but you passed.”

Charlie didn’t answer, still face down on the floor. Jonny had said, “She passed?”

“She did,” he said, looking away from Charlie, now regarding Jonny. “We can find a way for you two to stay here. I want you in my building.”

Jonny’s heart pounded and despite the arrogance and meanness in Reza’s voice, he felt like it was good news and he wanted to share with Charlie. He said to her while she lay on the floor, “Hear that, Charlie?” He saw her head nod. She’d stopped spitting and was on her elbows and knees.

Reza, very seriously as if this was a business negotiation, said, “Yeah, Jonny, we can work this out. The first of the month until it’s paid. You understand?”

He nodded, though he didn’t really understand.

Reza reached down and grabbed Charlie’s bare heel. Her foot curled up and recoiled from his touch.

Reza said to her, “You’re very beautiful, you know? I like you a lot. Aren’t you happy that you can stay?” Jonny saw that she nodded again.

“Good,” Reza exclaimed with a clap of his hands, then with a glance at his watch he got up, said, “I’ve got to get going, I got a million things to do.” Then he stood and held out a hand to Jonny for him to shake it, said curtly, “Jonny.”

Jonny didn’t even know what to do. It was unlike any business negotiation he’d had before. He extended a hand to Reza’s big iron grip and shook.

Before he left, Reza got down on one knee, put a hand on Charlie’s back. He got close to her ear and whispered something to her. She nodded, and he soothed her, running his big hand in a circle on her narrow back. Slowly she rose to her knees and rested her open hands across her thighs.

Her head was bowed, her face hidden in her mane of thick ginger hair. Reza looked so he could see in her eyes, and then he said, “Okay?”

“Okay,” she whispered. He ran his hand in a few more circles, watched her with concern, then he left.

WHEN THE DOOR clicked behind Reza, Charlie had run off. Out of the kitchen, down the two steps to the family room and into the bathroom. She closed the door, but it wasn't locked. Jonny caught up with her, knocked and let himself in. He found her on her knees arms draped over the toilet seat, head in the bowl.

"Charlie?" he'd whispered.

"Yeah?" she said, her voice an echo in the porcelain bowl.

He didn't know what to say, but he entered, walked to the bowl and sat down between it and the tub and lay his back on the wall, his ear in the cool beaded condensation of the tank. "You okay?" he asked.

"No," she said.

Eased himself forward, took her pale hand where it lay over her elbow and rubbed a thumb up and down her fingers. "Really? You're not okay?"

"I'm fine," she said. She spat into the bowl again and her back heaved.

"Did you throw up?"

Her back began to shake as if she was sobbing. "He ... came in my mouth, Jonny." She sniffed wetly. "Jonny, he came right in my mouth."

He went to her and put his arms around her. His hips thrust back so she wouldn't feel his prominent erection. He hated Reza. He hated himself. Couldn't believe that it was him who put himself in such a horrible

situation. Couldn't believe the thing that Charlie had done so that they could stay in their home. He shushed her gently, making soft sounds in her ear, working his nose under her mane of hair and kissing the back of her ear.

"Are you okay?" she asked him now.

He was stunned. "Am *I* okay?"

"Do you hate me?" she whispered into the bowl.

"Baby, I could never hate you," he said and ran his hands up and down her shoulders.

"Are you sure?"

"Charlie, baby, I'm so sure. I love you so much." He held her for a while and felt her breathe. His arousal still did not go away.

Charlie slowly eased herself away from the bowl a little, lifting herself up to be propped on her elbows. Her hands ran her hair back from her face. She said, "Can you get me some bleach?"

"For what?"

"I want to rinse my mouth," she said.

"Not with bleach, Charlie."

"I have to."

"No, Charlie. Let me get you something ..."

He rose, went to the cupboard under the sink and brought her an almost full bottle of Listerine left over from their wealthier days. Sat next to her, lay his back against the wall and watched as she took the bottle and upended it.

"Don't drink it," he exclaimed. But she did, swallowing a few mouthfuls of the amber fluid. She barked it all up again into the toilet bowl, lunging herself forward and he went behind her and held back her hair. When she was done coughing and spitting she sipped the Listerine again, this time only spitting it back out.

He'd said, "Are you sure you're okay?"

“I’ll be fine,” she said. Her hand came up and touched her face, her fingertips working around her lips. She said, “Can you get me ... there’s a bag of peas in the freezer, can you bring them to the couch?”

“Sure,” he said. “Your mouth is sore?”

She grimaced, looked away and from behind her hair, she whispered, “His thing is just so big, Jonny.”

He groaned so she wouldn’t hear, sitting back away from her, working himself on his butt toward the door. His arousal was painful and prominent. His heart beat with incredible lust, but his soul was crushed by his weakness and his impotence.

Despite how horrible everything was that he had just witnessed, her dirty but honest appraisal of their landlord’s penis had brought him to the brink of an incredible feeling, so awful yet so lubricious. An orgasm had swelled, but his shame pushed it away at the last second. His ruined expulsion pulsed weakly into his underwear.

“WHAT DID you get me to watch?” she asked, her plate cleaned, every last bite consumed, swirling designs drawn in the sauce as she tried to scoop it all up with her fork.

“It’s a surprise,” he said, taking her dish and going to the sink.

“Just tell me,” she said. She gave him a funny pouting face that brightened his spirit.

“You heard of the Twilight Zone?”

“Yeah,” she said, her face expectant.

“I downloaded all the episodes. Black-and-white, you love black and white—”

“I do.”

“—It’s from like the sixties, and it’s just crazy, awful, weird horror stories and sci-fi ...”

She smiled.

“Is that okay?” he asked her.

She nodded and sucked her lower lip into her mouth. When it plopped out, she frowned, said, “You didn’t ... buy them? ...”

“No, Charlie. They are ... pirate—”

“Pirated, Jonny? You know how I feel ...”

He took both her hands in his and pleaded with her. “Charlie, you know we have no choice. We have no money, what are we supposed to do?”

“It’s okay,” she said.

“As long as we have each other, right?” he said.

“That’s right,” she agreed.

Jonny did the dishes. Stood at the sink and scrubbed them with vinegar from a restaurant packet and a tiny drop of Palmolive. They had to make their bottle last. Behind him, in the family room, he heard Charlie. She had padded down in her bare feet and sat on the couch. The TV was on now, and she was flipping through menus, trying to find his computer file folders so they could watch his downloaded Twilight Zone episodes.

When he was done, and the dishes were dry, he came down to the couch to join her. She seemed happy, the nervousness and anxiousness from before appearing to dissipate; his girl behaving like she would normally on a regular night, looking to settle in and watch some TV with him. He sat next to her on the couch and hiked a leg around her back so she could lay in the V of his lap. She did, putting herself sideways, and he stroked her hair.

“Start at the first one,” he whispered.

“I know how to do it,” she said with mock snark.

“Just push that button there,” he joked, pointing to the remote, and she moved it away. She made a mockery of him, thumbing all the buttons that she wasn’t supposed to press, plopping up menus on the screen and repeating, “This one? This one? This one?”

She got him laughing.

“HEY, it really is black and white,” Charlie said, and she nestled herself tighter to him as the first episode began.

They watched as a man in a flight suit wandered a deserted town, everywhere he goes it’s like people have been there moments before but he finds no one. Pots boiling, water dripping in a sink, cigar burning in an ashtray. Eventually, he goes mad and they see that he’s an astronaut in training and after prolonged sensory deprivation what they just watched was the madness in his mind. When it was done he asked her, “You like that?”

“Yeah,” she said earnestly, eyes wide. “Wish we had popcorn.”

He flinched, wished indeed they had popcorn. Wished this was like the old days when he would maybe right now—having skipped awful macaroni and cheese for dinner—order them a seven-course combo from The Golden Pagoda, the Chinese restaurant down the road. That’s the way it used to be. Pick up the phone, order in. They were much happier. Of course, it was all a lie back then. The money coming in was fraudulent.

“Me, too,” he said and rubbed his hand over her shoulder. They watched the second episode and the third. Charlie was rapt. She loved it. She looked up to him occasionally and said what she thought was going to happen. *Hey, you think ... Or, I bet that guy ...* He loved to see her happy again.

During the fourth episode, she drifted off. Instead of running it back he just filled her in what she had missed. She made it through the sixth and the seventh but it was late when they watched the eighth.

During the eighth episode, she fell right asleep. He’d been working his hand around her body, pressing it into warm comfortable places. Even while she was awake, slipping his hand a little under her sweatshirt to touch her bare skin. Now that she was asleep he eased his hand under her clothing again. This time up under her sweatshirt and angling down, feeling her soft

smooth stomach. Dipping lower, fingertips under her pajama pants, finding the trim of her panties. He eased his fingers underneath ...

“What are you doing?”

“Nothing,” he said.

“Your hand is in my pants,” she said.

“Yeah, so?”

She put her hand over top of his, let him keep it under her pants but pinched his fingers in hers through the cotton. She held it in place and they watched the eighth episode to the end. The whole time all he could think about was the smooth feel of her delicate skin under his touch. He wanted to dip lower. Should have been able to. She was his wife. Plenty of times on this couch, he would just start touching her. She wouldn't object. Used to be she would giggle. Reza had changed them. Now for whatever reason, he felt like he didn't deserve her. That he needed permission. And that he didn't deserve that permission.

So when she slept again, his hand slid lower. Under her panties, ever so slowly, ever so sneakily, touching lower and lower, feeling the warm skin under his fingers become warmer as they reached her center, found the smooth swell of her mound, her cleft in the center. Very smooth. Shaved completely bald, moisturized, prepared ... He was right. Though he knew he was all along. Now confirmed, he felt another little punch in the stomach.

Tomorrow was the big day. The day the big evil monster came and had his way with her. Only instead of slipping a toilet paper tube laced with razor blades like a Vietcong prostitute might do, his wife had pampered her pretty privates. Shaved them, made them appealing. Welcoming another man's intrusion. He began to swell against her back.

Charlie liked it ... she fucking A liked it, didn't she? She liked being taken by that brute. By that arrogant cologne-wearing animal with his big animal cock. His shy pretty wife that was all his and his alone loved being shared. Loved the touch of her other man.

His finger slipped and touched, explored the swelling shapes of his wife's most private spot. She stirred, said, "Jonny?"

"You shaved it," he said.

She sat up, pulling his hand from between her legs. "What are you doing?" she said, turning between his legs to look in his eyes.

"You shaved yourself."

"What? ... So? ..."

"You shaved yourself for him."

She hugged herself, her eyes wanting to look away, lowering instead. "So?"

Jonny said, "So? So what does that mean?"

"What do you think it means?"

"I don't even want to say."

"So, don't say it then."

"I won't."

"Good." She turned, went to lay herself back against him, sat up again. "You know, maybe if you didn't get me into this mess ..."

"I know ..."

"You ever think maybe this is the worst thing that's ever happened in my entire life?"

"Is it?"

"You ever think it is?"

He held her hand.

"Jonny, I don't want to be embarrassed. Okay? We both know what he's going to do to me tomorrow. I brush my teeth before I go to the dentist, it doesn't mean I like going to the dentist."

It didn't mean that she didn't though, did it? He shrugged.

He said, "Would you kiss me?"

She bit her lip, eyes turned down then they darted up and his heart burst when their gaze connected. She dug an elbow into him, purposely, smirking

and he grunted. She climbed up so that their lips could meet. He kissed her, and all his imaginations about how his wife was falling for the man that she spread her legs for so they could stay in their apartment were washed away. He felt love in her kiss ... her love for him, and his faith restored.

SINCE THE NEXT DAY, the first of the month, was a Thursday, Charlie had called in sick. Knew she would have to because of the agreement with their landlord.

Jonny fiddled with code, his workstation angled so he could watch The Twilight Zone, Charlie laying on the couch. They'd had breakfast together, pancakes again just like the last first of the month. Charlie was nervous the whole meal, eyes darting to the door.

During the morning she watched six more episodes of The Twilight Zone while Jonny banged out code, her laying on the couch in clean and pretty pajamas, a cushion pulled to cover her stomach. He watched TV while he worked, and when he would glance over at Charlie he would often find her nervously checking the time or looking up at the door. Occasionally there were sounds from elsewhere in the building, bumps, and voices, people passing in the hall. She would pause the show and sit up straight, turn in the couch so her eyes were on the door. It wasn't Reza.

They had lunch together. Two peanut butter sandwiches, sitting on the couch, and Jonny took a break and watched an entire episode with her. Charlie's legs jumped and twitched, her knees bouncing nervously. One time, he reached out and lay a hand on her knee to steady her. She smiled and bit her lip.

In the afternoon he returned to work, a new freelance job came in, and he lay out a contract with them. He also finished a new set of angel wings for the Koreans, though they hadn't paid him yet, sent those off, and then worked on some difficult coding for a problem-solving puzzle.

By dinnertime, Charlie was twisting with agony. Drawn up on the couch, every sound in the building made her jump. She didn't want to eat. He offered to make something and she said no. She held her stomach and pulled her knees up to her chest. Her face twisted with tension.

When the sun went down she began whining. "Do you think he's coming? You think he's going to come, Jonny?"

"Do you want him to, or do you not want him to come?" he said meanly.

"If he doesn't come is he going to kick us out?"

"No, I don't think so. He just ... I don't know ... he'll just come tomorrow ..."

"It has to be the first, Jonny," she cried.

She began pacing. Her bare feet darting back and forth in front of the couch. She would look out the window though they didn't face anywhere that she may see Reza coming. But if it made her feel better ...

Eleven o'clock rolled around and she was moaning. He'd pulled out the bed from the couch so she could sleep but she wasn't able to. He worked while Charlie lay on the bed with a forearm draped across her eyes. "Oh Jonny, he's not going to come. We're going to have to leave ..."

"No, we won't, Charlie ..."

"We will, Jonny. We will ... All the things I did ...? ... And we still end up on the street ...? Oh, Jonny ..."

"Stop it, Charlie," he said, making his tone serious and paternal. "What is your problem?"

She darted up in bed. "My problem? My problem? ..."

He turned to face her and as he did a loud and firm knock rattled the apartment door making both of them jump. Charlie let out a shriek, short and clipped, her hand slapping over her mouth to stop it.

Jonny said, “Looks like you got your wish.”

“JONNY, DON’T SAY THAT.” Charlie stood in front of the couch staring at him with tented eyebrows and a look of worry. She rubbed an arm. “Please, don’t ...”

He shrugged, kept his face blank. “Go. Just go get the door. Don’t keep him waiting.”

“Jonny, please ...” she said, but now she was moving. Making her way toward the front door, her head turned to keep her eyes on him. She wanted to see him smile but he wouldn’t do that. She looked away as she made it to the steps, mounted them, and he lost sight of her as she got in the kitchen. The clicking of the bolt and the rattle of the chain came, then he heard the door open. Charlie said, “Hi.”

Reza said, “There’s my Charlie.”

Then something happened between them, maybe an embrace, a hug. Jonny hefted himself out of his office chair feeling like he weighed a thousand pounds. He shuffled his way to the bottom of the steps.

Reza held both of Charlie’s hands in each of his. He looked down at Jonny, said, “Oh hey there, Jonny.”

Jonny said, “It’s awfully late.”

Reza smiled, one side of his beard pulling up a flash of white teeth, then he said, “It is indeed.”

Their landlord was dressed for the evening. He wore a black tailored suit and shining shoes. No tie, a black shirt buttoned right up to the collar.

Jonny checked his watch, it was 11 P.M. “We thought you weren’t coming,” he said.

“And now, here I am,” he said. He swung Charlie’s arms back and forth gently. At his feet, Jonny noticed there were two shoppers—paper bags with looped twine handles and tissue paper that puffed out like pastel flames.

Reza said, “Come on up, Jonny. Come sit at the table. You stay with me, Charlie.”

Jonny rolled his eyes, took the steps slowly, went to the kitchen table and dropped himself down.

Reza asked Charlie, “How did your husband do this month?”

“How did he do ...?”

“Did he let you down?”

Charlie lowered her eyes, said, “No, he worked really hard.”

Reza’s gaze moved from Charlie over to regard Jonny. He said to Jonny, “Is that true?”

Jonny nodded, not looking at Reza, looking at his wife.

Reza said, “But Charlie is still coming with me? Boy, oh boy ...”

Charlie said, “He made enough money, but we’ll be broke if we pay you ...”

Reza regarded Charlie now, his head cocked confidently, eyes going from her feet up to her down-turned face. Then he looked to Jonny, did the same to him, checking him out from top to toe. He said, “I’m going to wager something. Charlie, if Jonny pays me, I’ll still support you. I’ll support you and you don’t have to do the things I want.”

She seemed to brighten, not entirely, but enough to lift her eyes. She looked at Reza then over at Jonny. It wasn’t exactly excitement. Jonny hoped to see her jump, say *Of course he can*, relieved that she wouldn’t have to spread her legs. But instead, she still seemed fraught with worry.

Reza noticed as well, smirking and chuckling. He lifted her chin with his first knuckle and looked in her eye. “Don’t worry, Charlie, I’ll fuck you next month, I’m sure of it.” Then he caressed a shoulder and turned to Jonny. “Well, Jonny boy? Let’s have it.”

“The money?”

“Pay me my money,” he said, confirming what he wanted.

“Jonny ...” Charlie said.

Jonny said, “The whole amount? ...”

“Of course, Jonny. The whole amount.”

His shoulders slumped and his head dipped forward with regret. “I can’t.”

Charlie sighed audibly, and Jonny worried that it wasn’t disappointment in her, but that it was excitement.

Charlie said, “Jonny ... I thought you did it this month?”

“Charlie, baby ... the Koreans didn’t come through.”

Reza said, “Koreans?”

Jonny said to Charlie, “I’m sorry, baby, the Koreans haven’t paid me yet. They should have, but the money didn’t come through. Maybe I could check my account again ...”

Reza snapped his fingers and broke the moment.

“Stay where you are, Jonny. All three of us know what’s going to happen tonight. Okay? Just let it.”

DOWN THE HALL, he heard the squeak of a door open. They all turned their heads to the open apartment door. Footsteps then, and he wondered if someone was coming. But then he heard the metallic clang as the drawer for the garbage chute was opened and something dropped down. Another door opened, more footsteps, then there was talking. It was Mrs. Garcia from apartment 12, and it sounded like she was talking to Hank O’Reilly, a widowed senior citizen and notorious night owl who lived farther down on the far side of the hall. He couldn’t hear what they were saying, but it sounded like gossip.

Jonny said, “Can you close the door?”

Reza was looking in Charlie's eyes and she had turned her head down. Reza said, "Your apartment is so stuffy."

Jonny said, "Whatever."

Reza came to the table, put his hands on the chair opposite Jonny and pulled it away, turned it so he could face Charlie still standing by the open door. He sat down and crossed his legs, said, "I have something special planned for us tonight."

Charlie whispered, "Special?"

"Yes, we're going to have a wonderful evening. Can you show me your grooming?"

Charlie said, "My grooming?"

"I'm taking you out."

Jonny said, "You're not taking her out, too."

"Oh, I *am* taking her out ... I have a special night planned, and my date canceled. Now Charlie is my date."

Charlie dipped at the knees, and she gasped, "I can't go out."

Reza said, "Don't let me down. It would be very bad if the two of you let me down this evening. It's an important night and I need you there."

Jonny said, "Without me?"

Without looking at him, Reza said, "What would I need you for?"

"She's my wife—"

Charlie said, "Can't he come along?"

"No, he can't. Don't be ridiculous. Charlie, show me your grooming."

Charlie looked around nervously, chewing on her lower lip. She began to rock back and forth, swiveling at the hips, bare feet planted firmly on the floor. One hand went to her tummy and pulled up the bottom hem of her sweatshirt. She hooked a thumb into the front of her pajamas waistband. Slowly she eased it down until it pointed in a V and Jonny and Reza could see that she had shaved her mound.

Jonny said, "Charlie, just close the door."

Reza said, "Charlie, don't close the door. I want the door open."

The voices still continued down the hall, some mild laughter and then some more hushed tones as a particularly juicy bit of detail was related between the two. Charlie folded her arms up again.

Reza said, "Charlie, show me your grooming."

Charlie said, "I did."

"Show me properly."

Now Charlie looked to the right, to the open door, her brow furrowed. She put her hands in her waistband and slipped her pajamas down her hips and to the top of her thighs. She lifted the front of her sweatshirt again with one hand and put her hips forward. They both could clearly see her shaven mound. Her beautiful freckled pale creamy skin, the cleft swell of her sex.

"See?" Charlie said.

Reza said, "Turn around."

"Turn around?" she repeated.

Reza ran his index finger around in a circle. Charlie obeyed. Shuffling her feet in the same spot, she turned so that they could see her bare bottom.

Now Reza said, "Bend over."

She hesitated. They couldn't see her face, but Jonny knew it was twisting up right now. Her arms were folded, her hands tucked in her armpits.

Reza repeated, "Bend over, Charlie."

The conversation in the hall had stopped and there were shuffling footsteps on the carpet again. Charlie watched out the open door. But she obeyed Reza, slowly beginning to bend over.

Reza said, "Pull your cheeks apart, Charlie."

"Oh, no," she gasped. They could barely hear her.

Jonny said, "Reza ..."

Charlie's pale hands came up the backs of her thighs, over the swell of her rump. Her fingertips pressed into her soft flesh there and slowly peeled

her creases wide. She showed them her tiny pink anus, the slim ruffled lips of her dry sex. Showed them both that she had groomed herself very well, not a single stray hair, nor stubble, nor rash. Charlie was flawless between her legs.

Jonny hated that Reza had done it. Had humiliated her in that way. But between his legs, he was completely iron; throbbing steel. He wondered if Reza was the same.

“Now,” Reza said, “drop your pants for us, Charlie.”

Charlie offered no resistance this time. Growing comfortable with being asked to do dreadful things. She pushed her pajama pants down just a little bit and then they dropped to the floor on their own. She stood and stepped out of them. “Can I turn around?” she whispered.

Reza said, “Please ...”

She shuffled around in a circle again and faced him. Her lower lip had sucked into her mouth and her eyes were wet and blinking. She folded her arms again and Jonny could see, though it was warm, the skin on her thighs had turned to gooseflesh. She shivered.

Reza said, “Now your top.”

Jonny said, “Can’t she close the door, please?”

Reza said, “I told you, Jonny, your apartment is too stuffy. I like for there to be the flow of air.”

Jonny said, “Someone could come by.”

Reza laughed, said, “Could you imagine that? What an amazing thing they would see.”

They would, and by tomorrow the gossip would be all over the building. Mr. O’Reilly saw that nice young girl in Apartment 4 show her vagina to the landlord while her weird little husband watched. What would they all make of that?

“PLEASE ...” Charlie whimpered.

Reza said, “The door?”

Jonny said, “She wants you to close it.”

Reza ignored him, said, “Now take your top off, Charlie.”

The footsteps grew closer, the sound of someone coming down the hall echoing off of the concrete walls.

Reza said, “Please, Charlie.”

Charlie tucked her hands in the hem of her shirt, crossing them over in front of her, looking toward the door, her lower lip trembling. Slowly she eased the sweatshirt up, taking forever to do it.

The footsteps stopped outside, and they heard the sound of an apartment door opening then closing.

Charlie’s knees were shaking. But she removed her top. Pulled it up over her head and shook her hair out of it. Now she stood in front of them wearing nothing but a white bra. She covered herself, putting one hand between her legs and crossing an arm over her breasts.

Reza said, “The bra, too.”

Charlie turned her side to them, folded her arms behind her back and unclasped the bra. She let it fall forward, held it in her hands then quickly

tossed it onto the kitchen table and covered her arms across herself again. She clasped her thighs together and slipped her hand between her legs.

Reza said, "Charlie has an incredible body. Doesn't she, Jonny?"

Jonny agreed. "She does."

Reza's eyes went up and down her body and Charlie chewed the inside of her cheek. He said, "Truly incredible. The way she hides it all you wouldn't even know it was there. But look ... Exquisite. Perfection. Charlie, I brought you gifts. They're in those shopping bags. Open the blue one first."

Charlie darted her eyes to Jonny, showing him worry. "What's in there?" she said.

Reza said, "Open it and you will see."

Charlie squatted down completely naked, parted the open top pushing away pastel blue tissue and pulling out a garment box inside. Blazed in gold on the top of the box was the word, GUCCI.

Reza said, "Open it."

Charlie lay the box flat on the floor and squashed her bare breasts against her knees. Her hands worked the ribbon.

Reza and Jonny watched. Reza leaned to Jonny, said calmly, "Look at that body. Not an ounce of fat. Your wife is a thoroughbred."

Jonny's stomach fluttered. Now he was chewing his own lower lip like Charlie. Charlie, on the other hand, was moving quicker. Like a little girl on Christmas morning; getting the ribbon off, trying to open the lid, tossing it aside, parting the tissue paper with the gold seal and pulling out her gift.

She held a cocktail dress by the shoulders. Silk or chiffon, or something elegant. It shimmered in the kitchen lights. It was a deep royal blue, a perfect complement to his wife's creamy skin and apricot hair.

Charlie admired the dress, running her hands underneath it, seeing the way the fabric shone as her hand passed. "It's beautiful," she whispered.

Reza said, "You deserve it. It's nowhere near as beautiful as you, and I can't imagine how breathtaking the two of you will be together."

Charlie said, "Really? Really, it's for me?"

"Please," Reza said, "put it on."

"Can I?" Charlie asked Jonny.

Jonny shrugged his shoulders. "I don't care."

"Jonny ..."

Reza said, "Charlie, that dress is for you. I want you to wear it tonight."

Charlie said, "Where are we going?"

"I have an event. And I want you in that dress, on my arm."

"A date?"

"I'll make it worth your while."

Now Charlie was looking back at him again, "Jonny? ..."

"Go ahead," he said flatly.

Charlie's mouth moved around like she was going to say something but she didn't. She returned her gaze to the dress, her hands moving over it again, smoothing it, examining its tailoring. "It's really beautiful," she sighed quietly. Then, her head darting over her shoulder, sheepishly said to Reza, "I don't have any underwear."

Reza said, "Under a dress as beautiful as that a lady as beautiful as you doesn't wear a thing."

"They don't?" Charlie gasped.

"That dress goes over your bare body."

Charlie examined it again, her head working around, hair hanging down covering her face. She stood upright then, kept her side to them. She turned her back, put her feet through the dress, bent and pulled it up, shimmying her hips from side to side as she pulled it over her body.

Reza stood and walked behind her. There was a short zip at the top of the dress's back and Reza pulled it closed. Charlie jumped, not realizing he'd been so close and she turned, her face frightened.

Reza said, "I guessed on the size. You're a size 0?"

"I don't know," Charlie said.

"You don't know your dress size?"

Charlie shook her head no.

"It's shameful how much your husband lets you down."

"He doesn't let me down," Charlie said, her eyes darting from Reza to look at Jonny.

"Turn around," Reza said, "let me see what you look like."

"Okay," she whispered.

Reza took a step back and sat down again. Charlie turned and showed them her dress. It was beautiful, and Charlie was stunning in it. A shimmering metallic blue, swooping shapes that came over her shoulder and crossed over her breasts. The arms were bare, and the skirt was very short. Jonny pointed it out. "The skirt's a little short, isn't it? If you're not wearing panties ..."

Charlie ignored him, Reza saying, "Charlie, look in the other bag."

Charlie looked sheepish for a moment, standing in front of them in her bare feet and her beautiful dress; she bit her thumbnail and her lips curled on one side, a graceful smile. She said, "Is it shoes?"

Reza said, "Just look in the bag, Charlie." He was smiling too.

Now Charlie rolled her head around on her shoulders and Jonny couldn't ignore the smile that he saw on her face. Her fingers worked around like she was counting, touching her thumb to each of the fingertips. Then she resigned, turned, squatted down again.

Reza said, "Look how narrow her waist is, Jonny. You really married out of your league, didn't you?"

Jonny said, "She is beautiful."

"Mm-hm. Once she's revealed."

They watched as Charlie worked through the second shopping bag. Squatting next to it, her hands pulling out tufts of pink pastel paper and

drawing out an object that was obviously a shoe box.

Reza interrupted her, said, “Bring it here.” She stood and held the box at her waist and walked toward them. He said, “Just have a seat across from me,” and he turned the chair so it faced him. She sat down and they were knee-to-knee. “Open the box,” he said.

There was a wide gold organza ribbon, and she untied it, pulled off the lid. Charlie brought out a shoe. Black patent pump speckled with sparkling crystals, the sole a shining bright red.

“You know what that is?” Reza asked.

Charlie turned the shoe over and over, admiring it. She whispered, “No.”

Reza said, “It’s a Louboutin Sexy Strass. Very rare, never worn, but vintage. Those are Swarovski crystals. A very rare and exciting shoe for such a rare and exciting woman.”

“It’s so beautiful,” she said, mesmerized by the shoe, the crystals shining like stars and casting spots of light on Charlie’s perfect face.

“It costs more than what you pay for a month’s rent.”

Charlie gasped, her fingers curled on the shoe and she held it between her breasts. She said, “For a pair of shoes?”

Reza said, “Each shoe.”

Charlie said, “Each shoe?” and she held the shoe out again tenderly braced in her fingertips and admiring it.

Reza reached out and took it from her and tapped her knee. “Give me that pretty foot,” he said.

Charlie set the box on the floor, sat up, rested on the seat back, her hands on either side of her thighs, hands curled over the seat. She looked sheepishly at Jonny, then her gaze darted back to the shoe. She lifted her knee and Reza took her ankle. He put it between his thighs and ran his thumb over her instep. “Such beautiful feet,” he said.

He guided her knee higher, and it was clear that he could see up her skirt and between her legs. Charlie pressed her thighs together. Reza smiled. He examined her feet for a moment, said, "Such pretty toes." Then he slipped the shoe on her foot as Charlie pointed her toes to receive it. He slid the shoe on then held his hand out, said, "The other."

She reached down to the box, her knees touching so she wouldn't expose herself and pulled up the other shoe. Reza repeated the action, taking her ankle and slipping on the shoe.

"Now stand for me," he said, and he held his hands cupped together, leaning forward and putting his elbows on his knees.

"Okay," Charlie sighed. Her cheeks had grown rosy with excitement.

She stood, a little wobbly at first but then her legs straightened and strengthened, her muscles bulging above her knee. She took a few steps away and turned and looked over her shoulder at the both of them.

Reza said, "Excellent. Wouldn't you agree, Jonny?"

"She does look incredible," he said softly. He hated to see her this way. All that she had exposed now for everyone to see. At one time she had been his and only his. He put a ring on her finger and owned her. Then another man noticed. And dressed like this now, were she to appear in public, every man who put his eyes on her would know her charms.

"THAT'S A LOT OF EXPENSE," Jonny said, "for such a short date."

Charlie said, "Short date?"

Reza stood up, put his hands in his pockets and turned to regard Jonny.

Jonny continued, "Short date." He lay his hand on the kitchen table and drummed his fingers. He said, "It's 11:20 right now. Forty minutes from now will be the second of the month."

Reza said, "So?"

Jonny said, "So? Our deal was for the first of the month."

Charlie said, "Jonny ..."

Reza said, "It is the first of the month."

"Right now it is," Jonny said. "Do what you need to do but once it's midnight, your deal is invalid."

Reza acted unconcerned. He said, "No, it's valid. I'm here on the first and what I'm going to do with her begins now."

"Oh, really?" Jonny said. "So if you came on the first of the month you could stay in our bed for thirty days? Spend every day with us because it still counts because you got here on the first?"

Charlie sighed again, she looked nervously at Reza. He looked to her and gestured impatiently to Jonny without saying anything.

Charlie carefully walked to him in her new high heels. Clicking across their familiar linoleum floors with a new and frightening sound. When she was next to him she squatted down, and he looked at how much of her bare thighs were revealed in Reza's dress.

She whispered to him, "Jonny ... don't do this. Please, don't do this. I don't know what you think you're doing ... no, I do. I get it. You don't have to defend me. We know what the deal is. This isn't a court of law. What he's asking is fair."

"Fair?" he scoffed. "Fair?"

"You know the agreement. There is no letter of the law here. There's nothing to argue ..."

He said quietly, "Well, your honor, I'd like to argue that I think you fucking want to go out with him tonight."

She recoiled, her face startled as though he struck her.

"Jonny ... how could you say that?"

"I don't know," he admitted, looking away from both of them.

She stood now, and he looked up at her and saw her disappointed gaze. He felt humbled again. His petulant outburst as impotent as everything else he did these days.

“Fine,” he said. “Go. Go have fucking fun.”

Reza chuckled, adjusted his suit jacket, tugging at his lapels. “We will, Jonny. We will have fucking fun.” Now he held out his arm, gesturing for Charlie to come and take it, acting like he was some sort of gentleman. Fucking gorilla in a \$5000 suit, thinks he knows his manners.

Charlie walked to him, again carefully learning how to walk in such high heels. She put out an arm hooked in an L and he took it, pulled her elbow so that she was close to him. Jonny stood up and came behind them before they left. He said, “When will you be home?”

Charlie threw a look over her shoulder, her brow troubled, she whispered, “I don’t know—”

Reza said, “Don’t worry, Jonny. She’ll be home in one piece before dawn.”

Charlie looked to Reza, said, “Before dawn?”

“This is a big event. I have social duties.”

Jonny said, “Social duties, Mr. Darcy?”

Reza scowled, said, “Who’s that?” and Jonny chuckled to himself, his heart leaping when he saw a twinkling gleam in Charlie’s eyes. The corner of her mouth pulled up in a hidden smirk at his *Pride And Prejudice* joke.

“Never mind,” Jonny said, and he rested his hand on the handle of the open door.

“Let’s go, Charlie,” Reza said, “I’m going to show you the greatest night of your life.”

Then that moment between him and his wife was extinguished, that sparkle fizzled as her gaze turned to Reza and her wonderful smile remained for him as well. It was all he could think of as they walked out the door together. He came to the threshold, his toes touching onto the carpet of the hall and watched as the two of them sauntered toward the elevators. Reza was leaning close and whispering things to her. Charlie was leaning toward him and listening. If she laughed he would drop dead on-the-spot

right now. She didn't, and they made their way to the elevator banks. He couldn't watch anymore and stepped back into the kitchen and closed the door.

JONNY STOOD for a long while with his back to the apartment door, wishing to hear footsteps returning, his Charlie opening the door telling him it was all a big joke. She would take off those luxurious items, throw them in the garbage, she would sit with him and they would watch the rest of The Twilight Zone.

He waited long enough he knew that wasn't going to happen. None of this was a dream. All of it was a nightmare of his own concoction. His own real-life Twilight Zone episode. So X-rated that it was never aired.

He heaved himself from the door and headed down the two steps to the family room intending to topple into his chair and lose himself in coding. But he was so heavy, so enervated, when he passed the bed he threw himself on it instead, drew his knees up so he was in the fetal position. He began to moan. The moans pushed away idle thoughts that wanted to ponder all the things she would do without him tonight. He lay like that in absolute spiritual pain for the longest time. As his eyes grew heavy, and he almost escaped the torture, a gentle knock came to the door.

She was home. It was over. The torment was done.

He jumped up from the couch, that languid weight doffed and he was renewed with energy. She was home, she was home, she was home. Reza had taken her downstairs, all the preamble in the kitchen only a taunt. Oh,

he had fucked her; he was sure of it. Probably bent her over the console of his Porsche and fucked her from behind. But she was home, she was home, she was home. He jumped the two steps and slid in his socks to the front door.

When he opened it he discovered that it wasn't Charlie at all.

"Hey, man."

Jonny said, "What are you doing here?"

"Came to hang out," Demetrius said. "You invite me in?"

"Invite you in? Why would I invite you in?"

"Do or don't, don't matter. I'm coming in."

No, the gentle knock on his door was a ruse. Instead, it was the Welterweight MMA dynamo that Reza sponsored. Here for a visit.

"Why would you come here?" Jonny said.

Demetrius didn't answer, stepped into the kitchen brushing past Jonny. He wasn't mean or menacing, in fact, his face was held in mirthful exuberance. He wore casual clothes; an oversized sweatshirt that came below his waist, baggy pants, colorful unlaced running shoes. The strap for a pack on his back ran sideways at an angle over his shoulder. He unslung it now, closed the door, taking it out of Jonny's hands.

Demetrius said, "Told you, man. Just come to hang out." He held the backpack against his chest and ran the zipper across. Jonny had a sudden vision of him pulling out a pistol and putting a bullet between Jonny's eyes, leaving him dead on the kitchen floor, his wife now forever in the arms of the man who hired this killer.

"Check this out, man," Demetrius said, his deep voice indicating something special was coming. But what he brought out was not a gun, it was the colorful box for the fantasy PS4 game Gods Of War.

"God Of War?" Jonny whispered.

"That's the one," he said, trotting down to the family room, expecting Jonny to follow. He stopped at the couch, saw it pulled out to be a bed, said,

“Hey, you going to go to sleep?”

Jonny stepped down into the family room, said, “No, I have to work.”

Demetrius agreed. “Yeah, you do at that.”

Jonny said, “So, maybe you could come back another time. I got too much to do.”

“That’s okay. You work. I’m just gonna play.” He threw his bag onto a chair, went to his knees under the TV, spread the glass doors of the stereo unit, opened his case for the game and popped in the disc.

As Demetrius got up and returned, now going to one of the IKEA chairs, he said, “Go, go sit down. Work. Make some paper.”

Jonny watched him a while, watched as he sat down with one of Jonny’s controllers and thumbed through menus on his TV. He said, “You here to watch me?”

“Yeah,” he said without looking.

“Why?”

Demetrius said, “Reza call me. Said you was talking back.”

“Hardly,” Jonny said.

“Whatever. He don’t like it. He said I come watch you. Make sure you don’t show up at the club with a gun. You got a gun, Jonny?”

“No,” he said.

Demetrius said, “I told Reza you didn’t.”

“What if I did? You think I’d go to this club or wherever and do something ... final.”

“You any kind of man you would.”

Jonny shook his head, unfolded his arms, watched as Demetrius got into the game and began, not paying any attention to him now. He went to his workstation, set himself down, and tried to code.

That lasted for not more than fifteen minutes. The things that Demetrius said raced through his mind. Possibilities. Things a man *should* do. Then came the things another man *was* doing. The way another man owned his

wife right now. Sure, just for one day out of thirty-one, but just the same—for one day he turned Jonny into nothing in his wife's life. He knew that Reza would fuck her tonight. Had seen him do it many times. Had seen how rough he was with Charlie. Saw how Charlie could take it though. His stomach fluttered thinking despite how rough Reza was with her she still would come. Watching your wife orgasm while being pounded by another man was devastating. How the fuck would he code anything right now? Checked his account and saw the money had come in from the Koreans. *Now* it comes in. He turned in his chair and watched the video game for a while.

Demetrius wasn't that good. While he wasn't terrible, there were things that he wasn't doing. Jonny got up and joined him, sat down with his back against the identical IKEA chair next to Demetrius.

Demetrius was on to him, said, "You here to critique?"

"There's things you're missing ..."

"I heard that," he said. "Things you missing, too."

FOR HALF AN HOUR Jonny showed Demetrius better techniques to do the things he wanted to do in God Of War. Demetrius was eager to learn. Resistant at first, then his pride easing and recognizing this was a chance to obtain some knowledge. Jonny explained how the game worked. The big picture. Showed him better techniques, maneuvers that he didn't know ...

Demetrius brought out a baggie from his backpack and took some pills and Jonny asked, "What are those?"

He said, "You don't want any of these. Ain't drugs. Just some BCAAs."

Jonny said, "What do they do?"

Demetrius said, "Just vitamins. Protein synthesis ..."

He let it hang and Jonny realized he didn't really know what they did. In the bag, he also had a bottle of water and he broke the cap and took a long

swig, swallowing his pills. He offered Jonny some beef jerky and Jonny took a piece.

“Thanks,” he said. “Hey, I have UFC.”

“Oh yeah? What fight is tonight?”

“No, not a fight,” Jonny said. “The game. We could play head-to-head.”

“Fire it up,” Demetrius said.

Jonny got it going, and they played for two hours. It was fun because it was two hours he was able to stop thinking about what might be happening. But eventually, his insides had grown so tight and as much as he pushed the thoughts away while beating Demetrius’s ass with every player they tried, it got to where he couldn’t stand it anymore. At the end of a six-round mega match that Demetrius came very close to actually winning for once, Demetrius said, “You know, man, this was real life I beat your ass.”

Jonny said, “I know.”

Demetrius kept his eyes on him, surmising him. Then he said, “But you’re pretty good at this. On TV.”

“I know,” he said, then he sighed. “Reza thought I might be the kind of guy who would do something because he took my girl?”

“Yeah.”

“You know that he’s not really taking my girl, though, right? Not for real. It’s just for money. In lieu of money.”

“Money or not he got your girl tonight. A man do that he knows a good chance someone’s gonna show up cause some shit.”

“He thought I might do that?”

“I can’t believe you don’t.”

“Really?”

“He do what he’s doing to my girl ...? ... Shit, man ... he be dead.”

“Yeah. You can fight.”

“I ain’t encouraging you to do anything about it. Just saying Reza’s a smart man. He know what to expect from other men.”

“Teach me how to fight.”

“You? Teach you how to fight?”

“Yeah. Show me what I should do to Reza.”

Demetrius laughed, put his controller down and stood up. “All right, all right. Show me how you stand.”

Demetrius put up his fists in a very professional looking stance and Jonny tried to imitate it. Then he just threw out a jab so fast he didn’t see it. Didn’t hit him, just tapped his chin.

“You got to close that gap up, son.”

So Jonny did, closing his hands to block his mouth.

“That’s it, that’s it,” Demetrius said then his shoulder flinched and Jonny felt his ribs being slapped with the back of Demetrius’s fingers. “Gotta keep them elbows in, kid.”

“Yeah,” he said, but when he brought his elbows in, Demetrius flashed out a hook and flicked Jonny on the cheek. This time it hurt. “Hey,” he said, stepping away and holding his mouth. “That hurt.”

Demetrius said, “Man, I didn’t even hit you ... this may be why he can take your girl ...”

Jonny lashed out, lunging and throwing a fist. Demetrius lazily swayed to one side, Jonny’s intensity making him laugh. He taunted him, saying, “Jonny got the fire.”

Jonny took a big swing that if he’d connected would have hurt Demetrius. He popped his eyebrows up and down and covered up again starting to take the sparring seriously.

“Hey, Jonny, you know Reza likes your girl ...”

“I know,” he said, throwing out a jab that Demetrius slapped away.

“No, man, I mean he really like your girl.”

Jonny jabbed again and then tried an uppercut but hurt his knuckles on Demetrius’s elbows.

“Yeah, man, we came by her work yesterday, Reza brought her lunch ...”

“What?”

“Yeah, we stop by the library, he bring her sushi ...”

“He did not,” he said, whipping his fist now as hard as he could, wishing he would connect.

“He didn’t fuck her or nothin, girl at work, but Jonny, you shoulda seen her face light up when she saw him coming ...”

That made Jonny madder than he could ever remember. Now he thrashed, swinging, taking steps, backing Demetrius up, striking wildly and missing. Demetrius bobbed and weaved, laughing the whole time. As he got him backed up to the red IKEA chairs, Jonny, red with fury, slashed his leg up and tried to kick Demetrius in the balls.

Demetrius grabbed his leg, hooking a forearm under his ankle, the other one locking under his knee and then surged forward, throwing Jonny onto his back, Demetrius coming down to land on top of him. Demetrius’s legs sprawled out on either side and Jonny couldn’t get him off. But now Demetrius was mad. He lifted himself up and away, straddled Jonny around his hips. He didn’t say anything but Jonny knew he was going to be hit. Demetrius slapped him right across the mouth. Not too hard that it rattled his brain, hard enough that he felt his lips swell.

Jonny threw his hands up between them, scratching him, pulling at his sweatshirt but Demetrius grabbed his wrists and peeled them away. Demetrius said, “Man, you a little bitch.” He got down real low next to his ear and said, “Jonny, you think he got that big cock in your girl right now?” Jonny struggled underneath him.

Demetrius laughed, spread his legs wide again so he couldn’t be removed. He chuckled and whispered, “I bet she moaning right now. Bet she moaning and squirming underneath him. You know she liked it, right? Know she liked that cock...”

“Shut up,” Jonny grunted, struggling with him, trying to wrestle out of his grip. He could taste his own blood in his mouth.

“Oh Reza, you feel so good,” Demetrius said in a high girlish voice, imitating his Charlie. “Ew, you’re so big, Reza, my little Jonny has such a tiny pee-pee ...”

“Get fucking off me,” he growled.

Demetrius laughed, and in Charlie’s voice again, said, “Ah, ah, oh, I’m coming, I’m coming ...”

“Get the fuck off me,” Jonny said in his most sincerely vengeful voice. He twisted and writhed under Demetrius, but Demetrius had him pinned.

Now he was gasping in Charlie’s voice, “Reza, come inside me, come inside me, I want to feel it ...” He broke off laughing after that and let him go and Jonny squirmed across the floor and sat with his back against the side of his bed. He rubbed his wrists and watched Demetrius hold his belly he was laughing so hard.

“It’s not funny,” he said. His mouth stung and when he touched his hand to it, he winced. Could feel that it had begun to swell.

Demetrius still laughed, subsiding though, taking deep breaths. Demetrius said, “No, it ain’t funny. Ain’t funny, man, but you got me laughing.”

“Some bodyguard you are,” Jonny said. “Provoking me into wanting to do something. Aren’t you supposed to protect him?”

Demetrius put his back against the IKEA chair and drew up his knees, draped his arms over them. “Man, I’m telling you ... It ain’t in you. Why I come with video games. Take my job serious and all, but you ain’t nothing to worry about.”

“Until I am,” Jonny said.

“Oooh,” Demetrius moaned with wide white eyes, twinkling his fingers, taunting him with theatrical fear. Then he said, “No, you ain’t. You like it too much.”

“No, I don’t.”

“You do,” he said with a shrug. “That a roll of dimes I felt?”

“A roll of—”

“Against the inside of my leg ...”

“—dimes?” Then Jonny said, “Oh,” and he shrugged. The taunting had aroused him.

“Hey, don’t sweat it. Embrace it, man, that’s what I say.”

“That’s what you say?”

Demetrius patted the spot next to him, indicating for Jonny to come and join him. “Hey, that’s your thing. That’s cool. You get your bills paid ... I know you twisted up inside but you get off on it.”

“I do not.” Jonny sat next to him. Demetrius handed him a controller and Jonny took it. As Demetrius scrolled through the game menu, selecting another two-player battle, he said, “Ay, you might deny it, but you happy. I see you happy. I can tell you Reza’s happy. I sure as shit know Charlie’s happy ...”

“Fuck off.”

“Hey, you forget I had her? Forget I put my dick in your wife’s happy mouth?”

“Whatever.”

Demetrius started over, “Yeah, you happy. Reza’s happy. Charlie’s happy. Ain’t you feel sorry for me? I’m the one that got to work. Come here, babysit your ass.” He started the game and their two characters began to brawl.

Jonny said, “You’re getting paid.”

He could sense Demetrius shrugging, seeing his point. “That’s true,” Demetrius said.

“Paid to play video games,” Jonny said.

“Hey, just like you. Except I actually get paid.”

WHEN JONNY WOKE, the black sky had faded to a threatening gunmetal. He snapped upright with a snort. He was in bed, still clothed. Demetrius had laid a blanket over him. He darted his eyes left and right, whipped his head around. Demetrius was gone. The PlayStation turned off, but the TV left on, a flickering paler shade of gray than the sky. He heard now what woke him. Voices in the hall, a rattling as a key scored the lock. A pewter cat face key chain scraping the door under the handle; a familiar and heart-bursting sound. She really was home.

He jumped out of bed as quickly as he could given the stiffness brought to him by sleep. He made his way to the stairs to the kitchen, and he saw the door swing open. Two black figures tumbled past the threshold of the unlit apartment. She wasn't alone. That should have been obvious, given the voices. He wasn't prepared, though, to see them together.

It was Reza and Charlie. Charlie was laughing. Whatever Reza was saying was so fucking hilarious his shy wife was giggling. She stumbled in first and Reza closed the door behind them. She was dotty on her heels, very unsteady, and she turned in an awkward circle to face their landlord and he thrust himself against her; pinning her to the side of their fridge hard enough that it rattled and a magnet that held their phone bill clattered to the

floor. As the bill wafted, seesawing the air to rest on the linoleum, Reza shoved his tongue into Charlie's mouth.

She groaned and inhaled deeply, accepting his tongue. Her hand gripped his thick upper arm and Jonny watched her fingertips dent his expensive suit coat. Their kiss turned to chuckling, Reza's a low animal grumble.

He broke the kiss and looked into her eyes. She looked in his too, and her face broke with a wide smile. He got close to her and whispered something and she giggled again. When her eyes opened, she saw Jonny past Reza's arm, standing and glowering from the family room.

"Oh, Jonny!"

Jonny said, "Looks like you had a good time."

Reza knew he was there and his big hands went down her waist over her thighs, slipping up underneath her skirt and lifting it a little higher. Pulling it so it bunched at the crease of her buttocks; if she still wore no panties, which he was sure she didn't, her pussy would be bare between them.

Charlie squirmed from Reza, her hands coming down now and tugging her skirt low, as low as it would go, which wasn't very. She looked embarrassed. Looked like she'd been caught doing something naughty.

Reza turned around, his hands coming off of her. He slipped them in his pockets, said, "Told you I'd have her home before sunup."

Jonny didn't say anything, continued to stare at the two of them. Concentrating more on his wife. Jonny said, "You have to go to work today, Charlie. You can't call in sick two days in a row."

Her eyes darted downward again, and she said, "I know."

Reza said, "Such a shame you're with a man like Jonny. You were my girl, you wouldn't work at all. I'd send you to the spa today. Sleep in til noon, wake up, two Vietnamese girls rub your back until dinner."

Jonny said, "Fuck off." It made Reza sneer, his eyes twinkling in the morning light, dazzling even in their dim kitchen. "You can go now."

Reza went to the door unaffected by Jonny's false bravado, opened it, turned and said, "What she did last night for me going to make an easy month for you two." He winked at Charlie and she looked away. Then he slipped back into the hall and closed the door behind him.

THEY STARED at each other in the dark. Twenty feet apart, him standing in the center of the family room looking up at her, she made all sorts of pained and funny faces, looking down on him from the kitchen. Her mouth twisted around and he could see her eyes glistening.

"What?" she whined.

"I guess you had a lot of fun, didn't you?"

"Jonny, don't be like that."

"It's, like, five in the morning, Charlie."

"I know, I know ..." she said, and she heaved herself off of the fridge where she'd been leaning. She adjusted her dress again, walked to the top of the stairs on her toes looking very wobbly. She lifted each heel and removed her shoes. Now she came down in her bare feet to the family room, tossed the shoes onto a chair and flicked on a lamp that stood behind it. She said, "Jonny, please, don't be like that ..." Then she turned to come to him and skidded to a stop.

"Jonny, your face!"

He put his hand up and felt his lip and cheek were swollen.

"My God, Jonny. What happened to your face ...?"

She stumbled to him, gripped him with one hand, her other fingers smoothing along his neck as her beautiful emerald eyes wavered, taking in his injury. He took one of her wrists and pulled his face away.

"Does it hurt?" she gasped. "When I touch it?"

"It's fine," he said. "Leave it alone."

"How'd you get hurt?"

“You smell like cigarettes.”

She stepped back, her canine pinching her lower lip. “I do?”

He moved toward her, put his nose near her, said, “Cigarettes ... Charlie, you smell like booze ... You smell like weed ... Fucking weed, Charlie?”

Her posture slumped, and she looked away from him, then traipsed heavily toward their bed and threw herself on it.

“Charlie, did you do drugs?”

Charlie said, “What do you mean drugs?”

“Were you drinking?”

She clucked her tongue and reached around behind her trying to find the blanket that Demetrius had thrown over him while he slept. Fingers found it, snatched it and pulled it over her.

Jonny went to her, sat on the edge of the bed. “Hey, talk to me.”

“Talk to you? You’re being such a jerk right now.”

“How can you say I’m being a jerk? You know what it was like for me here tonight?”

“You know what it was like for me?” she said defiantly, eyes meeting his now. It startled him.

He quietly said, “Yeah, I don’t think it was hard at all.”

“Oh, you don’t?” she said, raising one eyebrow.

“Charlie, what’s wrong with you?”

“Nothing’s wrong with me,” she said, flopped back down and tried to pull the blanket to cover herself.

“Hey,” he said. Ran a hand up her bare calf and gripped her behind her knee. “Hey, don’t be like that. I’m sorry if I was being a jerk. I just had a really terrible night, I guess maybe I’m taking it out on you.”

“You are,” she said without looking at him.

“Well, sit up and talk to me. Tell me what happened.”

Her eyes were open, he could see them blinking. “Come on, Charlie. Don’t leave me out.”

She slowly sat up, leaned back on one hand. She looked beautiful, but he could see that her hair was a tangled mess. She always had a wild mane but right now her hair was unruly in a different way. Her makeup was gone as well. She left the house wearing very little, and now returned, it seemed she wore none. As if it had been worn off. Her skin shone in the low lamplight, her beautiful speckled creamy skin that he wanted so badly to touch right now. He ran his hand higher up past her knee, between it and the hem of her very short skirt. Her leg felt wonderful.

“You can tell me if you had a good time,” he said.

“I don’t know, Jonny. I didn’t have a bad time. I can tell you that I did not have a bad time. He was good to me.”

The fact that Reza was good to her and it was acknowledged by Charlie stung like the slap that had been delivered by Demetrius.

“He was good to you?”

“You know what he can be like. He wasn’t like that tonight.”

“Where did you go?”

“Mockingbird.”

“Mockingbird? What’s that?”

“Club on Houston Street. He invested in it. Tonight was their opening night. A soft launch. VIPs only.”

“Oh,” he said. Picturing her in a throng of the city’s very hot young VIPs. Without him. With Reza.

“What kind of club is it?” he asked.

“I don’t know,” she said. “Like a dance club. And a bar.”

“Were you drinking?”

“Is that okay?” she said sheepishly, her chin down, looking up at him through her brows like a scolded kid.

“You just don’t drink.”

“No. No, I don’t.”

“So you were drinking?”

She nodded.

“That’s okay, Charlie. I don’t mind that you were drinking.”

“You don’t?”

He shook his head for her and forced a smile on his face. About the greatest struggle he could imagine.

She seemed to soften now, said, “I did. It didn’t taste like alcohol. It was like pop. But I did get a little woozy.”

“How were your high heels?”

She giggled a little, said, “Tricky. I almost fell a couple times.”

“Can I kiss you?”

Now she nodded and smiled for him. He felt the tight grip that had held his heart when she walked in the door begin to loosen.

“Can I?”

“You can,” she said. She tilted her head back and pointed her chin at him, her eyes narrowed, her lips peeled back in a smile. He went over top of her and took her lips, sucked on them, pried her teeth apart with his tongue. When he felt hers against his, it was like he swooned. He put one arm around her and cradled her against him, pressed his body as flat to her as he could. He breathed her in. He smelled cigarettes, smelled booze, he smelled weed. He smelled cologne, too.

When their kiss broke, he sat up again and said, “You can tell me if you smoked weed.”

“I did,” she said. “I did a little bit in the limo.”

“In the limo?”

She nodded again and he could see that she was a little nervous telling him that, chewing the inside of her mouth like she did.

“He took a limo?”

“Yeah, we took a limo from here to the club and then back home again. It was me and him and these three other guys—”

“Three other guys? Who?”

“This really big guy from his gym. He was pretty funny. And then, like, this businessman who owns, I think, five restaurants in town. He was kind of dry but I think he’s smart. And then there was another young guy, I think he might be kind of mean.”

“Mean?”

“I don’t know, it was hard to tell. He was always scowling, and he never said anything.”

“Oh,” Jonny said, trying to picture his poor Charlie, timid as she was, in a fancy limousine with intimidating men. Every time he did, he pictured her on all fours though; a vicious image leaping out of the darkest recesses of his mind, flashing him vile scenes of her taking cocks up her ass and in her mouth.

“You okay?” she said.

He would’ve said *Okay* but he couldn’t speak. So he nodded and kept that funny smile on his face.

“I have to go pee,” she said. She stood, still a little wobbly even in bare feet, putting her hands out to the sides to balance herself.

“Ooh,” she said then, seeing her shoes on the IKEA chair, “ooh, my shoes,” and she stumbled to them, gathering them up in her arms and cradling them to her bosom.

Still having to pee, she crossed the room with her thighs pressed together, bending her legs only at her knees and shuffling. She stumbled to the far side where she kept her clothes in a tiny closet and dropped to the floor. She stood then, opened the door and cleared a space. Stooped down, picked up her shoes and carefully put them on a shelf. Admired them, then reached out and arranged them so they were angled nicely. She admired them again for another moment then closed the door.

Jonny rose off the bed, came behind and braced her, putting two hands on her back to steady her.

“Thanks,” she said. “Little dizzy.”

He guided her to the bathroom and went in with her. She didn't object, though it was as though she didn't notice him come in. She crossed her arms over and pulled the dress off, swaying her hips from side to side then dragging it up. He watched as her completely naked body was revealed. Felt weak in the knees again.

Dress off, dizzy because her eyes were closed, she swooned and had to throw her hands out on the counter to steady herself, her wedding ring making a loud metallic knock on the Formica.

"You sure you're okay?"

"I'm okay," she said. She took two steps and flipped up the lid of the toilet then turned and plopped herself down. She leaned her elbows on her knees and hung her head forward, her long beautiful ginger hair flowing over her legs. Bright tinkling ensued, a hissing sound underneath.

Her dress lay on the countertop, half in the sink and half spread on the counter. He could see stains on the underside of the skirt, below the waist. What would clearly be described as semen stains. His stomach bounced, and he grimaced. Caught his reflection in the mirror and saw an expression that mirrored exactly how he felt. Torn apart. Jealous, furious, in love, in lust, aroused, humbled ... worthless.

"I'll hang up your dress, okay?" he said

"Mm-kay," she moaned from under her hair, still tinkling away.

Jonny took a free hanger from her closet and ran hidden straps in the neck over the hook so it would stay in place and put it amongst her other things. Hated the idea that the semen stains may touch any of the clothes he might actually recognize her in, and he spread distance between the beautiful blue dress and the clothes she regularly wore. When he returned to the bathroom, they bumped into each other in the doorway.

"Ope," she laughed and covered her mouth.

He took her hand and guided her toward the pullout bed. She crawled up from the foot on all fours and then collapsed.

Jonny returned to the bathroom and flushed the toilet for her. When he got back to the bed her arm was thrashing again trying to find that blanket. She lay completely nude on the bed. She really was an incredible beauty.

He crawled up to join her, taking the blanket and gathering it to himself. He said, "Charlie, turn around. Don't go to sleep."

"Sorry, Jonny I have to sleep. I'm so tired."

"Okay. Just talk to me first. Then I'll let you sleep. I'll sit by you and wake you when you have to go to work."

"I can't go to work today, Jonny."

"Can't go to work? You have to. You have to go to work, Charlie."

"Jonny, I'm so tired. There's no way I can go to work today. Call in sick for me."

"Charlie, are you crazy? You can't skip work again."

"But I *am* sick, Jonny. I have to get up in three hours and go to work ...? I can't do that ..."

"You have to, Charlie. What if you lose your job?"

She groaned. Rolled her head so she could look in his eyes. Stared at him for a while, blinking, then said, "Please, Jonny. I have to sleep. Just call in sick for me."

Now that they were face-to-face—and she seemed vulnerable laying naked on her back, her head angled towards his, her hair spread out around her, eyes narrowed from lack of sleep and drugs and booze—he confronted her with it: "He fucked you?"

She didn't avert her gaze, his words hadn't affected her at all. She stayed staring, blinking. She said, "You know he did."

"I know he did," he said. "Did he use a condom?"

She still held his gaze, said, "No, he never uses condoms, Jonny. You know that, too."

"So he came inside you?"

Now she didn't answer.

“Isn’t it close to—”

“It’s fine,” she said grimly.

He said, “Did he make you come?”

That made her close her eyes. Those narrow slits winking shut, eyelashes fluttering. He watched her breathe.

He repeated, “Charlie, did he make you come?”

She raised her eyebrows but kept her eyes closed. “Yes, he made me come, Jonny.”

Didn’t know if he expected some victory for dragging that information out of her, but he won, got it from her. Now he didn’t want the victory. He changed the subject. “What was the club like?”

“Will you call in sick for me?”

“Fine, I will.”

“Will you?” she said high and breathy and hopeful, a slight smile on her sleepy face.

“Yes.”

“Okay, the club was crazy, Jonny. There were so many people. The music was so loud, the place was unreal ... It looked like a palace ...”

“Sounds nice.”

“It was so nice. It was like a palace but it was all lit up with fluorescent lights ... No, like, neon lights. In purples and pinks. We got everything for free. We had canapés, we had some drinks that came in these little tumblers —”

“Shots?”

“Yeah, shots. They were really sweet.”

“And what did you do there?”

“I don’t know,” she said. “Just talk to people ... and we did some dancing.”

“Dancing, Charlie? You don’t dance ...”

“No. But there were people there and they taught me. Reza taught me, too. Taught me all kinds of dances and stuff.”

“Sit up, Charlie,” he said. “Talk to me. It’s important.”

Her eyes fluttered open again, and she saw his serious face. “Okay,” she said. She sat herself up and then scooted so she could rest her back on the couch cushions. She reached her hand out and made grabby fingers, indicating she wanted the blanket he held. He handed it to her, and she lay it to cover herself. It was the worst thing because this whole process of interrogation and her nudity had him throbbing right now. Hard and erect yet so jealous and hurt there was a lump the size of a softball in his throat, just above his heart.

“Charlie, tell me ...”

She cocked her head, said, “Tell you what?”

“Tell me ... how he fucked you.”

Now she cocked her head to the other side, regarding him, studying him. “Really?” she asked.

“Please, tell me ...”

“Why would you want to hear that?”

“I have to know.”

“You know he did. You can imagine. Do you have to know? Or do you want to know?”

He was a little shaken by her boldness. Analyzing him that way, his usually shy and demure wife willing to do anything he wanted without protest.

“I have a right to know,” he said.

“A right to know, Jonny? Why? Because you’re my husband?”

“You’re my wife.”

“I am your wife. So just tell me the truth. Tell me why you want to hear the details.”

“You can’t keep things from me, Charlie.”

“You can’t keep things from me either, Jonny.”

“What do I keep from you?”

“You’ve kept a lot from me, Jonny. Isn’t it obvious now?”

“Don’t ...”

“So, show me,” she said.

“Show you what?”

“Show me your thing,” she said.

His heart jumped. “My thing?”

“Show it to me, Jonny. I want to see your penis.”

“Why?”

“Why not?” Now her gaze lowered between his legs.

“So what?” he said defiantly, shrugging it off, admitting to his arousal.

“Why does it make you hard, Jonny?”

“I don’t know why it does.”

“I’m right, though? You’re hard?”

“Yeah.”

“Show it to me.”

JONNY SHOULD HAVE BEEN eager to show her but for some reason he was reluctant. She stared him down until the sound of his heart in his ears beat the lust into his brain.

She'd been with Reza tonight. Reza was much larger. He put a thumb into the front of his sweatpants and tugged them down. He wore no underwear, and his small slender endowment sprung up out of his dense pubic hair. He watched his wife's eyes as she regarded it. A little smirk tugged at one side of her smile.

"I knew you had an erection."

"I do," he said still holding the pants down, feeling his pulse race through his dick, so excited that she was looking at it. It was crazy, this was his wife, and she'd seen it many times.

He said, "You've only seen two in your life?"

Her eyes darted up to his, and the smirk turned to a real smile. She said, "Penises?"

He nodded.

Her eyes darted back down and she huddled up in her blanket. "Yeah, I've only seen two. In real life." She sighed, let her woolen cloak part, her bare arms coming out now. He caught a glimpse of her nude body, her pink sex between her legs. She reached out and took his penis in her hand. He

gasped a sharp intake of air and had to close his eyes. His brain had done a somersault. Clear excitement streamed from him and rolled over her thumb.

Charlie said, "You don't like it ... Do you? Like it when Reza does things to me?"

"No," he groaned. "I hate it. I really hate it."

Charlie whispered, "Your penis likes it?"

He said, "My penis likes it."

Charlie chuckled lightly and shook what she had in her hand, squeezed like she was choking it. "Stupid penis," she whispered.

He groaned again, heart pounding even harder now. He said, "You've only seen two?"

"I told you."

"Which one do you like better?"

She didn't answer and his eyes fluttered open. Found his wife looking at him intently, her brow furrowed. She said, "My husband's."

"You don't like his?"

"It's weird. It looks like something that would've been on one of the farm animals back home."

"Like a donkey?"

"Like a big old donkey," she agreed, watching her hand as it started to stroke ever so lightly up and down his shaft.

"Charlie?"

"What?" she said, eyes still lowered on what she was doing to her husband.

"Did he ... Did he come by your work?"

The stroking stopped. She was looking at him again, the intensity returned. "Jonny ..."

"Did he?"

"How did you know?"

"I know everything," he said mysteriously.

“How would you know that?” she said, more to herself than him.

“Did he come by the library?”

“Yeah.”

“Did you do anything?”

“Dirty?”

“Yeah.”

“No, Jonny.”

“You sure.”

“I’m sure. He brought me lunch. He brought me sushi and ... he told me to shave,” she said, the last part of the sentence making her wince and bite her lip.

“That’s why you shaved?”

“He told me not to tell you ...”

Jonny got up on his knees then lowered his lips to hers. She let go of his erection and it sprung up and tapped his belly. He took her lips and she let him, her lips parting, her body leaning back to the seat cushions. His hands slipped the blanket over her shoulders and now she was bare. While they kissed he rose the shirt up his body and threw it aside.

They stared at each other for a moment, eyes wet and blinking, not saying anything. Then her hands went to his waistband that scored across his thighs and she tugged them lower. He rolled to the side and lay next to her and they got his pants right off. Now they were both naked, husband and wife. They lay side-by-side looking in each other’s eyes and Jonny stroked her hair.

Her eyes showed great puzzlement, an innocent country girl who loved books, now in the city, learning all its evils. A husband who lied to protect her. A husband who failed her. A new man in her life, at once cruel and also giving. Taking her, dominating her. She was such a frail and fragile thing. So innocent. His lips attacked hers again, and his hand ran sensuous circles

on her naked back. He groaned in her mouth when he felt that sweet hand grip his erection again.

“I love you so much, Charlie,” he whispered.

“I love you, too, Jonny,” she said. She smelled so different than the Charlie he knew. The Charlie he knew smelled like soap, smelled like clean laundry. Sometimes toothpaste. This Charlie, this dirty Charlie in bed with him, had been with another man tonight. Not just their landlord coming to collect the rent and taking in trade the pleasure between her legs, this woman had gone on a date with him. Gone out and been entertained. Wined and dined and then fucked in a limousine. She was so different. Cigarettes and whiskey in her hair, weed in her mouth and around her ears. His bad girl was very exciting.

He kissed at her neck now, running his tongue behind her ear, tugging on the lobe with his teeth. He kissed lower down her collar, nibbling on her clavicle, lower, finding a nipple and plucking it. Her chest began to heave; an excitement in her as well. His demure wife couldn't get enough tonight. Nine inches of gnarly Iraqi cock couldn't sate her. Kissed lower, running his tongue along a rib, cresting to her linea alba and then following it until it rippled over her the belly button set in her tight stomach. Above him, she whispered, “Oh, no, Jonny ...”

But oh, yes, Charlie. It was going to happen. He kissed lower and her hips swayed on the mattress. She brought her arms up, forearms crossing on her face hiding herself away. Her legs opened. He took the point of her hipbone and bit it. She gasped. From there it was a quick and slippery line run with his tongue along the crease of her thigh following it to the warm and exciting heat that he sought.

Now she closed her legs. Closed them around his ears, her creamy thighs pressing against him, not closing off the sounds of her protest. “No, no, no, Jonny ... Oh, please don't ...”

Her pussy smelled like semen. Another man's product shot up inside her, now leaking out and spreading through her creases. He smelled cologne. Another man's cologne. Something musky and spicy. His tongue swiped, flattened wide and spread over all of her delicate folds. He felt his head being squeezed like a vice between her thighs. She started to plead, "Oh, please no, stop ..."

He parted her then, striking his tongue to a point and probing inside her. Tasted copper, her membranes probably scratched and scored by their landlord's thick hairy cock. It scored in out of her at a tremendous pace tonight. Punishing her poor pink privates. His delicate girl, taking something so big and ugly. He felt himself spew more excitement from his tip, running down his shaft, cold drips falling from his scrotum.

Charlie looked down her bare body at him, watching, her legs parted slightly. Her mouth hung open, trembling, her brow furrowed with multiple thin lines. "Oh, gross, Jonny, don't ... he came inside me. Jonny, I haven't showered, I'm still leaking ..."

He resumed his passionate suckling, taking up mouthfuls of her beautiful soft flesh and pulling and sucking, running his tongue through it. Charlie's mouth fell open wider, her plump lower lip shining with wet. Her belly began fluttering, heaving up and down. Her breaths came raspy now, and she tucked her hands under her rump and presented her sex to him.

With a hand, he spread one knee wider, wanting to breathe now, wanting room to work. He ran his tongue up and down, stuck it inside as far as it could go, felt a gushing. As he probed deeper, warm product seeped from inside her, running down his chin. His mind reeled backward in a tumbling circle, his heart pounded in his chest. Charlie cried out above him, twisting and writhing, legs open and eager now.

Charlie whispered, "Oh Jonny, oh, keep going, lick it all up, Jonny, clean my ... clean my..."

He looked up, saw her passion-bewildered expression. “Say it,” he whispered.

“Clean my ...”

“Pussy ...”

She jerked violently, and her head rocked back. She cried, “Pussy. Oh, my pussy, Jonny ... Clean my pussy, oh, please, clean it ...”

“I ... am,” he grunted, a wet muffled sound as she humped his sopping wet face.

“Do it ... good, Jonny. He comes ... ah-a lot. Those big ... balls shoot so much of his stuff into me ... I mm-leak so much after I’m with him ...”

Her trembling fists gathered up the top sheet and pulled as tight as she could. He pounded her with his tongue, he licked her clean, the whole while his once innocent girl encouraging him. What was once considered vile now bringing exultations from her. She gasped and cried breathy affirmations to him. Chanting *Yes, yes, that’s it*, even once babbling *Oh, my goodness*.

And then it happened; his Charlie came. Those trembling fists slashing down and pounding into the mattress once, her back arching, her tummy drawn tight as a drum. She moaned until her voice disappeared and just a creak drew out from her throat. Then she collapsed, snorting and heaving.

NOW HE CLIMBED up the bed with gasping breaths, throwing himself down to join her. Her chest rose and fell in furious heaves, her nipples tightened to extended buds. He ran a hand up her stomach and watched goosebumps hump on her breasts. She covered her face, hid from him. She whispered, "Oh no, Jonny, you shouldn't have done that ..."

"I wanted to ..."

She cried, "Oh, that was so terrible ..."

"I made you come."

"I ... I shouldn't have. That was just so awful ..."

"I'm going to do it every time."

She didn't answer, and he watched her bare breasts a long time as her breathing returned to normal. At last, she let her hands fall down to her sides, and she turned to him.

He repeated, "I'm going to do it every time."

She held his gaze with a serious face as long as she could and then finally one corner of her mouth poked up in a smile. Then the more she tried to hide that smile the more it gained control of her face. She covered up again with her hands.

He pried them from her, kissed her forehead. She watched him expectantly.

“What?”

“Nothing,” she said. She cuddled up against him, his penis poking her in her side. Her hand came down while her gaze stayed on his. She took his hardness and stroked it. Her mouth worked around, she licked her lips. Tossed herself on the bed and turned her back to him wiggling her butt. He turned on his side and spooned with her. His hand swept around her front, smoothed over her perfect body down her belly between her legs. Found her wet V, still leaking, slick from his ministrations. He ran his middle finger up and down, under her hood. She moaned.

He said, “So you liked it tonight?”

“Yeah,” she whispered. “I had a lot of fun.”

“I mean when he fucked you.”

“Oh,” she said.

“You liked it?”

She didn't answer but he could feel her nodding. He kissed the back of her ear.

“And he made you come?”

She nodded again.

He said, “We never talk about it. Never talk about—”

“No. We don't.”

“We should ...”

“Maybe,” she said.

“Before ... it was too weird.”

“It's still weird,” she said.

“Still weird,” he admitted. “But less weird.”

She shrugged, wiggled herself against him. He ran his hand over her hip, slipping behind her, probing now between her labia from behind, his wrist in the hot seam between her ass cheeks. He got her moaning again.

“What did you think the first time?”

“In the kitchen?”

“Yeah, in the kitchen. When he took it out and showed it to you ... What did you think of it?”

“I thought it was fake. I thought it was a joke. For a second I thought maybe you two were playing a joke on me and that was the punch-line. When I knew you weren’t I was freaked out.”

“It’s really big.”

“It’s really big,” she agreed.

“Do you like his size?”

“Yeah, I like his size.”

“You like his cock?”

“It’s ugly.”

“But you like it?”

Now she didn’t answer, but she turned and he could see her regarding him from the corner of her eye. She opened her legs, lifting one knee high. He dipped himself lower, got his hand at the base of his cock and angled it straight out. He slipped up and down her slippery seam, whispered, “You’re not too sore?”

“No, I think I’m getting used to how big he is.”

“Used to it?”

“It doesn’t hurt as much.”

“Does it feel good?”

“Kind of.”

He eased himself inside her and she took him with no protest. No gasp, no tightness, not even a quiet moan. He gave her everything, sinking in until his pubic hair squashed against her rump.

“Do you still like mine?”

“Yeah,” she whispered.

“Can you feel it?”

She nodded quickly.

“You sure?”

“I feel it, Jonny.”

“What does Reza’s feel like?”

“Huge,” she said.

“Really?”

“It stretches me. Right up inside, too, like, in my stomach.”

He ran his hand in a circle just below her belly button. “Here?”

She lay a hand on top of his, warm and damp but loving. “Yes,” she said.

“You like it? I know you do ...”

“I guess I do,” she said as he slowly began to work himself in and out, watching her face as he did.

“Tell me what happened tonight,” he said.

“Okay,” she said but stayed quiet and Jonny saw her mouth working around and her eyes blinking. He was as hard as he could be, his roll of dimes slipping in and out of her wet insides.

“Tell me,” he said.

“In the limo ... In the limo when we were on our way there ...”

“Yeah?”

“We were having fun, and he gave me a glass of champagne. We got stuck in traffic ...”

“You got stuck in traffic, and then ...?”

“He got real close to me and told me to go down on him.”

“Oh no, Charlie.”

“I figured he would ask that.”

“You weren't surprised?”

“I was embarrassed because all those other guys were there.”

“This was in front of those guys?”

“Yeah, they were all watching. They didn't know what he said, but they were all there.”

“You ... you did it?”

“Yeah, you know I did. I have to.”

“I know. So what did you do?”

“I didn't argue. I just did it.”

“How?”

“You sure?”

“God, Charlie, please tell me ...”

Her hips began to swivel, maybe his own excitement bringing some to her now too.

She said, “I got on my knees between his legs. He did his zipper down and then everybody knew what was going to happen.”

“They watched you?”

She nodded and gasped, rump pushing against him. “Yeah, they were watching the whole time. Reza did his zipper open and his big thing was sticking out. I just shut them out, and I did what he wanted.”

“What did you do?”

“I put my mouth over him and I sucked on it.”

“Oh no, Charlie, the other guys ... You didn't ...”

“Like with Demetrius? No ...”

“You sure?”

“I wouldn't lie, Jonny.”

“I know you wouldn't. I hope you wouldn't.”

“I wouldn't.”

“So they just watched?”

“The mean guy watched. The older guy who owns the restaurants ...? He played with himself ... And so did the big guy from his gym.”

“They jerked off?”

“I think they jerked off,” she said.

“Did you see their cocks?”

She nodded and licked her lips. “Just through their clothes. They rubbed themselves through their pants.”

“You saw their bulges?”

She nodded again.

“Then what happened?”

“I just kept doing what I was doing, going up and down on Reza, sucking on him, but I was so worried that he was going to make me do it to them, too.”

“You didn't want to?”

“Of course not, Jonny ...”

“Did you ... did you make him come?”

“Ah,” she gasped, eyes closed as if she were recollecting. His intrusion to her insides brought sticky wet sounds from between her legs.

“Did he come in your mouth?”

“Uh-huh,” she breathed.

“He came in your mouth, Charlie?”

“Mm,” she sucked her lips, gasped when he thrust quicker and harder.

“He came in my mouth, Jonny, and I swallowed it.”

“You swallowed?”

She nodded, her face furrowing with shame.

“It's okay, Charlie. What else were you going to do?”

“There was nowhere to spit it out and all those guys were watching me ...”

“You're such a good girl ...”

“I *am* a good girl, Jonny, I *am* ...”

“I know you are, baby, I meant it for real,” he said, kissing the point of her jaw under her ear. “Then what?”

“In the limo? That was it. I just got back up and sat down next to him again. The big muscle guy from his gym gave me a napkin to clean myself and a glass of champagne.”

Her story had Jonny gasping now, his steely shaft slipping in and out of her, a high bright tickle zipping from his hole to his eyeballs, choking off

his breath.

“Then on the dance floor ... when Reza was teaching me to dance ...? It was really packed, like, people all jammed together, and he ... he put his fingers inside me ...”

“What? ... Inside you?”

“Yeah, like, he lifted my dress a little and no one could see and he was behind me ... and I danced on his fingers, like, wiggled my butt against him ...?”

“That’s so dirty ...”

“I know,” she agreed.

“Did you like it?”

“It felt ... it made me ... come ...”

“You came on the dance floor? With all those people?”

“Yeah,” she gasped now, brought his hand over to cover her breast and the hardness of her nipple shocked him.

“Oh my gosh, Charlie, I wish I could have seen that ...”

“You do?”

“Charlie, you’re so sexy ...”

“Am I?”

“The sexiest thing ever ...”

“Mmnh,” she mumbled as she came again, her insides giving him a rapid succession of squeezes and he could see her tummy trembling.

“Jonny ...? oh, Jonny ...?” she gasped.

“What, Charlie?”

“When he ... mm, when he finally put it in me ... I really, really wanted it ...”

“Where?”

“In my pussy?”

“Where? Where in the city?”

“In the limo ... we were alone a-and I couldn’t wait for it. He made me wait like he knew I wanted it ... I thought maybe he wasn’t going to do it ...”

“That’s okay—”

“I’m sorry, Jonny, I ... I asked him to ...”

“To?”

“To do it, to—”

“Fuck?”

“I-I asked him to f-fuck me, Jonny. I wanted it so bad. I had drinks and a good time and the things he did, Jonny, with his fingers, oh, Jonny, he had me ... we smoked weed because he said he likes to before bed so he can chill and then I smoked, too, and, Jonny, I asked him to please fuck me ...”

“Oh, Charlie ...”

“I’m not good at all Jonny, I’m not ...”

She cried as her head thrashed in the pillow. She was hurt and ashamed but her sex was dripping wet, their hips bashing with wet mucous sounds.

“You’re so good, Charlie, so good ... you’re doing it for us ...”

“I am Jonny, I am ...”

“It’s okay, baby, tell me more.”

“He ... he grabbed me and kissed me and we ... we made out and his hands went all over me but I just ... just wanted him inside me so bad ...”

“What did you do?”

“I crawled over ... there was a bar and I lay over that and we knocked all the bottles off and I pulled up—”

“You pulled up your dress?”

“I pulled it up, and I showed him my privates ... why would I do that, Jonny?” she cried.

“You’re so amazing, Charlie, you’re so hot ...”

“He took his thing out and I watched for it ... got excited, Jonny ... when he pulled it out that ugly skin slid back and that big beautiful bulb on the

end came out and then he was dribbling clear stuff out of his pee hole and I thought I was going to die ...”

“Holy, oh baby, you’re so hot ...”

“I wanted it in me and I begged him cause I knew all that stuff coming out of him would make his penis all slippery and I needed to feel it ...”

“Oh, shit, Charlie,” Jonny roared feeling a freight train coming down his tracks, overloaded and traveling way too fast.

“Then he put it in me slow and careful and I thought I was going to pass out it felt so good, Jonny ...”

“Oh Charlie, oh baby, tell me more ...”

“Then he ... he fucked me, Jonny, he did it so nice and smooth, he made me ... he made me come, Jonny, more than once and I ... I’m just so sorry, Jonny ...”

“Oh shit, oh shit,” he choked. He slapped himself into her like a misfiring piston. Clumsy and inarticulate, just hell-bent on delivering his meager payload. “H-he came in-inside you?” he stammered.

“He came inside me, Jonny, his come is so hot it burns my insides, burns me so deep ...”

That was it. He was exploding. Phosphorescent fireworks went off behind his eyes and his ears rang like he was in a church bell tower. He thrust deep over and over, and Charlie cried and writhed against him and he hoped he could deliver a tenth of the orgasm she’d just given him.

EPILOGUE

WHEN JONNY AWOKE AGAIN, the sun was shining bright and someone was coming into the apartment. He swiveled and jumped to the edge, throwing his feet down on the floor, his head darting around the room, left over fears from his night with Demetrius stabbing at him from his dreams. He got to his feet, stumbled toward the kitchen.

It wasn't Demetrius nor was it Reza. Standing in his kitchen holding two big white plastic bags was a ginger-haired angel. Sure, maybe her back was a little stooped, her face kind of puffy and held immobile, her eyes hidden by a pair of enormous cheap black sunglasses. But it was the morning of the second day of the month and she was all his.

"Charlie," he gasped, coming more awake now, stumbling up the stairs to join her. "Where were you? What are you doing?"

"Morning, Jonny. I got us some breakfast."

"Breakfast, Charlie? Aw, baby, you shouldn't have ... I would have gone out."

She leaned to accept a kiss on her cheek, then moved to the sink and heaved the shopping bags onto the counter like they weighed fifty pounds apiece. She sighed, "I needed other things, too."

"Other things?"

She held her temples in her cupped palms, hunched over at the sink now. “Advil, seltzer, ice cream, some cola ...”

He came to her and hugged her back. “You’re not feeling too good this morning, Charlie?”

He felt her shaking her head, then groaning as it may have made her dizzy.

“Baby, you could have given me a shopping list. I would love to get some things for you.”

She turned now, leaned her butt on the counter and that puffy mouth attempted an honest smile. She took her sunglasses off and blinked profusely. She said, “Take a look in the bag.”

“What did you get?”

“Just take a look, Jonny.”

One bag held her cola and ice cream and pharmaceuticals. The other was the one she indicated. It was a plastic bag as well, but inside he found a steaming paper bag folded over once and stapled. When he popped that staple and opened the bag, the smell of glorious greasy food slapped him in the face like Demetrius. Only this one he welcomed. His knees went a little weak, and he sighed, “Oh my God, that smells so good.”

“Doesn’t it?” she said behind him.

He turned around, said, “Baby, how did you pay—”

She kind of shrugged and looked away. He didn’t need to ask, he knew the answer. It was the money she earned last night doing all the things she told him about in bed. Reza had come through with money.

“Okay,” he said very quietly. He opened the other bag, said, “What else did you get?”

She snatched it from him, reaching out and closing her fist around the top of the bag and taking it. “Never mind,” she said. “I told you.”

“What can’t I see?”

They both looked at each other, and he had an idea. “Oh,” he said. “Maybe it wasn't okay that he didn't use a condom?”

“Get some plates,” she said as if she hadn't even heard him.

“Yeah,” he said, taking the cue and brightening himself up as well. He reached up into the cupboard and took down two plates.

Charlie had gone to the Beech-Nut Diner, a place they frequented when things were better, she ordered two Lumberjack Specials and a side order of extra bacon in a styrofoam clamshell. French toast, pancakes, scrambled eggs, sausage patty, real maple syrup, real butter ... his hands shook as he made two plates up for them.

“Twilight Zone?”

That was all Charlie needed to say and his heart swelled in his chest. They both had the day off, didn't they? He called in sick for her at 7 AM, left a message that she still wasn't any better and she would need another day. It would be just the two of them. The two of them, a fabulous meal earned on his wife's back, pirated episodes of The Twilight Zone, and not a fucking thing else. He wouldn't even look at his computer today.

While Jonny got the plates together, Charlie trotted down to the lower level and got herself back into a sweatshirt and PJ pants. He met her at the couch as she folded the bed away. The TV was on, the file folder open. He put the food down on the coffee table and they threw themselves on the couch and fired up the next episode. They demolished the food. Every morsel that she brought home in that bag disappeared in the next half an hour.

When it was all gone, he thought he might burst. Even Charlie thrust herself backward in the couch and she arched her back and heaved out an enormous pregnant belly and ran her hands in alternating circles over it. He looked and laughed, and then they realized that it might not actually be that funny. She flattened her tummy again and climbed over to hug him.

He held her for a while and they watched the show. Saw a woman who was terrorized by a twin in her reflection in a bus station mirror. Thought how his Charlie had a twin, too. Another Charlie that wasn't his and did bad things. Only that one didn't live in a mirror, it lived in the real world.

Vestiges of the other Charlie remained in her hair and around her neck: he smelled her remnants. The faintest traces of smoke, and weed, and alcohol, even Reza's musky cologne. If he tugged her panties down, he might even catch a whiff of her other man's semen still. As Charlie pointed out, Reza produced large volumes.

Charlie leaned forward and took her full glass of pop, sat back and upended it. He watched her throat bulge and jump as she gulped down every last drop, the cola bouncing and chugging in the glass until it was empty.

He laughed. "Charlie ...?"

She leaned forward blinking wetly, her mouth wriggling around. Thumped the glass on the coffee table with a loud wallop. She looked like something was wrong.

"Charlie ...?" he asked again.

Her eyes were tearing, water streaming from them. Then she slapped her hands over her mouth and let out a long but magically ladylike belch. Trying to keep it quiet, but having no alternative than to let it all out. It went on and on and he watched with his mouth open. When it was over she pinched her nose and squinted tears from her eyes, then fanned her face and turned away.

He climbed on top of her, laughing in her ear and she hid her face from him. "How rude," he said.

She laughed, "Oh my, gosh, I shouldn't have done that."

"Are you a bad girl?"

"No," she said.

"There's things I shouldn't do either, and I did them. Am I a bad boy?"

“I don't know,” she said, still not looking at him.

He said, “Like last night? You know what I mean ...”

“No,” she whispered.

“The thing ... What I did ...”

“I don't know, Jonny.”

“Yeah, you do ...”

She shook her head no.

“You telling me you don't remember?”

She shrugged. He sat up and pulled her with him, gripping her sweatshirt and making her sit upright. She looked sullen now, her lower lip pouting.

He said, “Remember ... the things we talked about last night ...?”

She shook her head no again.

“Charlie, yes you do ...”

“Jonny ... I just don't want to talk about it.”

“Okay, but you do remember?”

“No, Jonny. I don't remember anything I did or anything I said, okay?” She looked at him firmly, her plump mouth set in a thin line and her eyes upset. She remembered everything.

“Okay, Charlie, baby. I love you.”

“I love you, too.”

He let her off the hook, pulled her so she lay on top of him and smooched her perfect lips, her long hair falling around his ears. An odor wafted from under her sweatshirt.

She made a face and said, “I should get in the shower.”

“I don't want you to. I like you all warm—”

“And stinky?”

“Yeah, kind of. Warm and stinky.”

She regarded him, her smile switching from one side to the other, his wife thinking something, narrowing her eyes at him.

“What?” he laughed.

She pushed herself to him, warm air from next to her body breezing across his nose. She giggled breathily.

When he caressed her shoulder, she kissed the back of his hand. She said, “Just hold me. I want to do this all weekend.”

“Lay on the couch?”

She smiled warmly, then sat up and stretched. She reached to the table and showed him her empty glass, holding it in his face and wiggling it.

He went to the kitchen, opened the fridge, so happy to see items in there that were frivolous and full of sugar, knowing that later this evening they might get into that ice cream in the freezer. Shit, they might even make a phone call down to The Golden Pagoda.

When he put the pop away and closed the fridge, he looked up and saw the calendar. That grid of thirty-five perfect squares had sudden salacious meaning. It tightened his belly. Each one of those squares would bring them to the next first of the month. He groaned a little, thinking about it. Hating it but also feeling an excitement pulse through him.

Only thirty more days ...

AFTERWORD

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